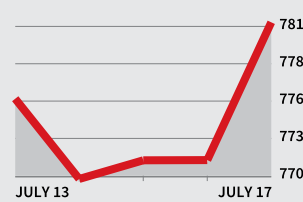


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 78151.45 (+582.06)

IN FOCUS



	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	24334.30	+127.40
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.18	+0.14
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.28	+0.96
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	140594.00	-2200
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	215474.00	-4916



CURRENT ACCOUNT.

We are aiming for ₹50,000 crore biz with retail and digital expansion, says Ajithkumar KK, Chairman and MD, Dhanlaxmi Bank p11

CORPORATE FILE.

Inox Clean spent ₹25,000 crore on acquiring integrated global clean energy platform assets p9

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

CLEANTECH

Why record RE penetration raises fresh concerns



At 12:29 hours on July 13, India achieved a record that went almost unnoticed. Wind and solar together accounted for 42.79 per cent of the electricity being generated in the country at that instant — the highest ever share of variable renewable energy (VRE) in the grid. The high penetration of VRE is indeed a cause for celebration; equally, it is a warning to grid operators. **p8**

SPARK

Menswear leaps past the tried-and-tested

Twenty-eight-year-old Nithin doesn't remember the last time he walked into a legacy menswear store to buy work clothes. His wardrobe is stitched together from brands his father had never heard of. For a growing tribe of young Indian men, dressing well is no longer about buying a suit once every few years. It's about building a wardrobe that reflects personality. **p10**

FCNR(B) mobilisation slow; banks upbeat on Sept targets

EARLY TRENDS. Collections at \$3-6 b in six weeks; tax-friendly jurisdictions spur NRI interest

Maresh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

The initial excitement around the FCNR (B) deposit scheme appears to be moderating, with inflows likely to remain well below the \$50-70 billion market estimates that surfaced after the scheme's launch. Nearly six weeks into the programme, banks have mobilised only about \$3-6 billion, prompting a more cautious outlook across the industry.

Among public sector banks that have announced their FCNR inflow target till September 2026, Punjab National Bank remains the most optimistic. Managing Director and CEO Ashok Chandra said PNB expects FCNR (B) deposits to reach \$2.5 billion by September, up from the current \$425 million. Union Bank of India is targeting \$1.5-2 billion by September-end, while Indian Bank aims to raise \$2 billion and has a visible pipeline of nearly \$1 billion. South Indian Bank is targeting \$1 billion, and the Central Bank of India has set a goal of \$400 million. Major private-sector

Dollar hunt

	Currently Mobilised	Target (by September 2026)
Union Bank	106	2,000
Central Bank	8.8	400
RBL Bank	150	-
Punjab National Bank	425	2,500
Indian Bank	140	2,000
South Indian bank	-	1,000
State Bank of India*	1,900	-
Bank of Baroda*	273	-
Canara Bank*	80	-
Total	3,082.8	7,900

Source: Company & *Industry: HDFC Bank, ICICI bank, Kotak Bank, Federal Bank & YES Bank refrained from disclosing any FCNR number during the earnings call

lenders have not disclosed mobilisation figures, preferring to review progress at the end of the September quarter. Bankers nevertheless expect collections to accelerate as awareness among NRIs improves and marketing efforts intensify.

MARGIN WATCH

Private lenders are also mindful of profitability concerns. ICICI Bank has indicated that FCNR (B) deposits could mildly dilute net interest margins because of the higher rates offered on foreign-currency deposits.

Most incremental inflows are expected from retail

NRIs in Gulf countries, particularly the UAE, along with pockets of demand from Singapore and Hong Kong. Demand from the US and Australia is expected to remain relatively muted because investors there have access to competing fixed-income alternatives.

Experts note that higher returns alone are insufficient to drive NRI investment decisions. Tax treatment in the country of residence, FEMA compliance requirements, currency exposure and broader portfolio considerations all influence participation. While interest earned on FCNR deposits is tax-free

in India for eligible NRIs, PIOs and OCIs meeting prescribed conditions, investors must also consider tax liabilities in their home countries. This has resulted in stronger interest from tax-friendly jurisdictions such as the UAE and Hong Kong, while investors in the US and UK remain more cautious.

YIELD SQUEEZE

Another factor limiting enthusiasm is the narrowing India-US yield differential. The spread between Indian and US 3-5-year yields has fallen from roughly 650-800 basis points in 2013 to around 200-220 basis points currently, reducing the carry advantage and lowering the attractiveness of FCNR investments.

Leverage has emerged as a key competitive feature, with most Indian banks offering between eight and 12 times leverage, while some overseas institutions reportedly provide up to 19 times. However, Axis Bank MD & CEO Amitabh Chaudhry said customer interest ultimately depends on overall transaction economics and returns rather than headline leverage multiples alone.

Centre ring-fences 72 lakh tonnes of rice from FCI for ethanol push

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

As the Centre scales up grain-based ethanol production to support higher blending targets and reduce dependence on imported fossil fuels, the Food Ministry has reserved 72 lakh tonnes (lt) of rice from official stocks for distilleries in the next ethanol season, up from 52 lt allocated in the 2025-26 supply year.

It has also allocated an additional 55 lt of 100 per cent broken rice for sale through e-auction, which ethanol producers can procure, potentially making biofuel production more profitable.

BIOFUEL PUSH

In a communication to the Food Corporation of India (FCI) on July 16, the Ministry stated that the competent authority has approved the sale of 72 lt of rice at ₹2,390/quintal to ethanol distilleries for production during the ethanol supply year (ESY) 2026-27 (November 2026 to October 2027), sources said.

Further, the Ministry has earmarked 55 lt under the sale of resultant broken rice produced under the Rice Milling Transformation (RMT) scheme through



An additional 55 lt of 100% broken rice will be auctioned and may go to ethanol distilleries **SRINATH M**

sources said it could also be diverted for ethanol production, improving distillery economics.

Also, as the government is considering increasing the ethanol blending share with petrol from the current 20 per cent, with testing and trials are underway, rice from the government's stocks may ensure steady supply of ethanol in case of lower sugarcane and maize production due to a deficient monsoon.

Against an annual ethanol production of nearly 2,000 crore litres, OMCs need 1,050-1,100 crore litres per year to meet the 20 per cent blending target.

For the sale of rice to State governments, their agencies, as well as for community kitchens without e-auctions, the government has allocated 16 lt at ₹2,320/quintal during July-October and another 32 lt at ₹2,390/quintal during November 2026-June 2027.

The government has, however, deferred allocations for national co-operatives such as Nafed, NCCF and Kendriya Bhandar for retail sale under the 'Bharat' brand, stating the quantity "will be intimated in due course".

These agencies had earlier sold 'Bharat' rice at government-notified prices.

Armenia and Saudi Arabia among six nations eyeing India's battle-tested Astra missiles

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

An in-principle agreement between India and Indonesia for Astra beyond-visual-range (BVR) air-to-air missiles, announced during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Jakarta earlier this month, has further boosted global interest in the indigenous weapon system, with at least six nations — including Armenia and Saudi Arabia — now showing interest in the combat-proven capability.

The quantity of Astra missiles and the deal's value will be finalised during subsequent contract negotiations between India and Indonesia, *businessline* had reported when the agreement was announced.

Sources said Armenia is at an advanced stage of talks with India to acquire Astra missiles, successfully deployed by the IAF's Su-30MKI fighter jets during Operation Sindoor. Engagements with Armenia and Saudi Arabia focus on integrating the weapon system onto their aircraft. Armenia has initiated advanced negotiations with India to integrate the Astra BVR air-to-air missile system onto Su-30SM fighter jets.

SHOW OF CONFIDENCE

Armenia's negotiations show confidence in Indian defence equipment. Armenia has already bought the Akash surface-to-air missile system, Pinaka multi-barrel rocket launchers, Swathi weapon-locating radars, 155mm Advanced Towed Ar-



Overseas buyers eye Astra after successful deployment during Operation Sindoor

tillery Gun System howitzers and ZEN anti-drone systems.

The Royal Saudi Air Force operates a mixed fleet of F-15S and F-15SA and Eurofighter Typhoons. Negotiations about integrating the Astra missiles on these platforms are on, sources stated. Astra's precision and lethality can be compared with the best in its class, including the PL 15 BVR air-to-air missiles of China. The

other advantage is that Astra is at least 70 per cent cheaper than its global alternative, sources said. The Ministry of Defence is keen to have indigenous air-to-air weapon systems with extended range on the IAF platforms.

Developed by the DRDO and manufactured by Bharat Dynamics Ltd (BDL), the Astra Mk-1 is a Mach 4.5 missile with a strike range between 80 and 110 km. India has also tested the Mk-2 version, carrying a range of 200-240 km. The Mk-3 version with a ramjet engine is at a development stage, with a proposed extended range beyond 300 km. Given the strong demand, the government has decided to involve the private sector in the manufacturing of the missiles, which until now has been the exclusive domain of BDL.

Prodigies create golden alchemy at Chemistry Olympiad

Bag a rich haul of four golds and clinch joint top position against 93 competing nations

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Indian STEM prodigies had a standout showing at the 58th International Chemistry Olympiad (IChO) held in Tashkent, Uzbekistan, bagging a historic all-gold medal haul and clinching the joint top position worldwide against 93 competing nations. This achievement was the latest in a streak of winning performances in Olympiads this year by Indian students, who picked up medals at the Biology and Physics Olympiads too.

At the 37th International Biology Olympiad (IBO) 2026 held in Vilnius, Lithuania, from July 12 to 19 2026, the Indian team of four students won one gold and three silver medals.

According to information from the Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education, Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, the four



Winning Indian team at the International Chemistry Olympiad **HBCSE**

winners of the Chemistry Olympiad were Debadatta Priyadarshi (gold) from Bhubaneswar, Odisha, Harshit Singla (gold) from Mandi Gobindgarh, Punjab, Kabeer Chhillar (gold) from Delhi, and Sandeep Kuchi (gold) from Hyderabad.

The Biology team comprised Bhavyaa Gunwal (gold) from Mahendragarh, Haryana, Soumil Maity (silver) from Howrah, West Bengal, Nishit Kalani (silver) from Pali, Rajasthan, and Anmol Kumar (silver) from Mansa, Punjab. India's

track record at the Chemistry Olympiad has been improving over the years, with the last 10 appearances yielding a strike rate of 43 per cent gold and 53 per cent silver medals, HBCSE said.

STRONG SHOW

This was India's 27th appearance at the IChO and its first-ever all-gold haul. Incidentally, this year's IChO, held between July 10 and 19, had 363 students from 93 countries, making it the biggest IChO to date.

In the Biology Olympiad,

this was India's 26th appearance. In the last 10 years, the gold and silver strike rates have been 25 per cent and 68 per cent respectively.

Anwesh Mazumdar, the National Co-ordinator for Science Olympiads from HBCSE TIFR, said the challenge had both theory and experimental components, and the teams posted heartening performances in both. Each theory problem takes about one hour to solve, and it's very rigorous, he added.

As for how, India can retain this talent, Mazumdar noted that the solution lies in making India's research institutions as robust as international ones. The students who win at these Olympiads are among the brightest in their countries, he said. Hence, to retain this talent, the solution lies in making India's research institutions as robust as international ones, he added.

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Green tribunal seeks
reply on TN gas leak

New Delhi: The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has sought responses from the Central Pollution Control Board and others in the case of ammonia gas leak at a seafood processing unit in Tamil Nadu on June 21 that claimed the lives of two migrant workers and injured over 60. The green body was hearing the matter where it had taken *suo motu* cognisance of a newspaper report regarding the gas leak. The matter is scheduled for hearing before the Southern Zonal Bench on August 31. **PH**

Delhi to add 2,800 AC
buses under PM E- Drive

New Delhi: The Delhi government will induct 2,800 new AC low-floor electric buses in the national capital under Phase-I of the PM E-Drive scheme, next year. The initiative is aimed at reducing pollution and strengthening Delhi's public transport system, according to the Chief Minister's Office. It also plans to expand its public transport fleet to around 14,000 buses by 2028-29. **ANI**

Infosys Q1 preview: Sequential growth likely to be aided by acquisitions

Sanjana B
Bangaluru

Infosys is set to announce its June quarter (Q1FY27) results on July 23. While the IT major is projected to deliver steady sequential constant currency (CC) revenue growth of around 2-2.2 per cent, supported by recent acquisitions and ongoing cost-efficiency measures, brokerages remain divided on its full-year outlook, with guidance estimates ranging from 1.5-3

Ram temple theft, NEET to dominate
Monsoon Session starting today

OPPOSITION DEMAND. Centre cannot maintain silence on a range of issues affecting the public, say leaders

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Opposition parties staged a symbolic walk-out on the issue of inviting the group of rebel TMC MPs to the all-party meeting convened ahead of the Monsoon session of the Parliament. While the government defended the invitation extended to the group who joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), Opposition leaders criticised the move saying the Lok Sabha Speaker is yet to approve any merger and the disqualification petitions filed by TMC against rebel MPs is still pending. Congress said it will raise issues related to NEET paper leak, education reforms, employment, farmers, as well as Ram temple donation 'theft', ethanol fuel, Manipur during the upcoming Monsoon session, starting today. Samajwadi Party said it would also raise activist Sonam

Wangchuk's hunger strike among other issues. "We raised these issues and demanded a discussion on them in Parliament. The most important being the theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya. The government should express its sensitivity to it. We are also seeing protests by students, but none from the government is taking moral responsibility," said Gaurav Gogoi, deputy leader of Congress in Lok Sabha. He said issues affecting common people when raised by Opposition are getting ignored by the government. "Be it ethanol, students' issues, *Sadan ki Chori* (defection/split in TMC, Shiv Sena), Manipur issue, temple theft... If the government runs away from these issues, then it will suffer," he said. Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said that the people want smooth functioning of Parliament and "not any turmoil" in the House, and urged all parties



(from left) Union Ministers Arjun Ram Meghwal, Kiren Rijiju, Rajnath Singh and JP Nadda at the all-party meeting ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament, in New Delhi **PH**

to give their positive support to Bills. "By protesting, no one is going to benefit politically. That is why I requested members of all political parties to take part in the proceedings wholeheartedly," he said. **EIGHT BILLS** Rijiju said the government has already listed eight Bills for the Monsoon Session, scheduled to continue till August 13, and if there is additional business, it will follow necessary procedures.

The Minister also said the government has noted the suggestions of the Opposition. Speaking to media after the all-party meeting, chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Rijiju also said NCPI requested recognition from the Lok Sabha Speaker and can't be ignored. It is the government's duty to invite everyone, he added. Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge shared a letter dated July 18 jointly written by him and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi to

Not in our backyard:
Thane residents protest
Amazon data centre plan



This is the first time that local residents in India are raising their concerns about such digital infrastructure

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Nearly a thousand residents of Thane district near Mumbai gathered at Balkum Naka to oppose the construction of Amazon's 422 MW data centre near housing societies and schools. The protesters demanded that the data centre be relocated to a properly planned industrial or technology zone rather than residential neighbourhoods. Residents gathered under the banner of *Wakeup Thanekars* (WUT) raised concern regarding the industrial-scale digital infrastructure project in the middle of an already densely populated residential area. Their concerns included added pressure to an already stressed regional water and power infrastructure, heat generation, noise pollution, traffic congestion and reduced green cover in an area known for its green space. "The movement is not to stop investment or technological progress but to identify a more suitable location for the data centre that balances economic development with the interests of citizens," said Dayanand Nene, member of the WUT. Organisers told *businessline* that the call for protest

came after mails and conversations with Amazon officials in the presence of Saurabh Rao, Municipal Commissioner. **EIA REPORT** Referring to the data centre's environment impact assessment (EIA) report, residents found out that the tech giant plans to set up a 422 MW data centre across 54.73 acres and the 193 diesel generator to be set up for backup power. Following the protest, the Commissioner has flagged the residents' demands to higher ups. An Amazon spokesperson said to *businessline*, "This facility will not draw or divert power from the local distribution grid, but through its own dedicated high-voltage substation. We recently announced that Amazon became water positive in India, returning more water to communities than it uses. Amazon does not currently use water for cooling in its data centers in India, including our Thane site, and we do not draw from the community's drinking or potable water for cooling purposes. Amazon takes a holistic approach to minimising both energy and water consumption while meeting the highest health, safety, and environmental standards."

IFSCA revises GIFT City credit rating
rules, mandates issuers to fact check

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Credit rating agencies (CRAs) operating in GIFT City in Gujarat will now have to give issuers an opportunity to review and clarify factual errors, omissions or misperceptions that could materially affect a credit rating before it is made public, under revised rules issued by the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA). The requirements are part of the amendments to the Master Circular for Credit Rating Agencies issued by the regulator this week, following consideration of stakeholder representations received during a public consultation and a review of global best practices. The revised framework comes into force with immediate effect.

The regulator, however, clarified that this requirement will not apply to unsolicited ratings and private credit rating assignments. **AMENDED NORMS** Under the amended norms, a CRA must, before issuing a rating action, provide the issuer with the "critical information and principal considerations upon which a credit rating will be based" and allow it to clarify "any factual errors, factual omissions, or factual misperceptions" that have or are likely to have a material effect on the rating. Explaining the rationale behind the move, a senior IFSCA official told the *businessline* that **RATING OUTCOMES** "This is to ensure that the issuer gets an opportunity to clarify the factual position. However, the rating is independent and is not based on

whether the rating is acceptable to the issuer or not," the official said. **RATING OUTCOMES** The regulator also sought to allay concerns that the new framework could allow issuers to influence rating outcomes. "The role of the issuer is limited to clarifying the factual accuracy of the information on which the rating is based. It does not provide issuers any right to negotiate, approve or challenge the analytical judgement or rating opinion of the CRA. The analytical assessment, application of methodology and final rating decision remain the independent responsibility of the CRA," the official said. Currently, CareEdge Global IFSC Ltd and S&P Global Ratings Singapore Pte. Ltd are the two credit rating agencies registered in GIFT City.

Brokerages extend earnings recovery in first quarter of
FY27 as diversified revenue streams drive growth

Our Bureau
Mumbai

India's brokerage industry extended its earnings recovery in the June quarter, with most major firms reporting double-digit profit growth as higher cash market activity, expanding margin funding books and diversification into wealth, commodities and distribution offset the lingering impact of derivatives regulations introduced in late 2024. The quarter also saw a widening gap in business models. Expanding beyond transaction-based broking into lending, distribution and other fee-based businesses has helped brokers deliver stronger earnings, while traditional brokers posted relatively steady growth. Groww led the pack, with parent Billionbrains Garage Ventures reporting a 94.4 per cent year-on-year jump in consolidated

Q1 financial snapshot		
Brokerage	Revenue	PAT
Groww	1,501.00	735.00
Angel One	1,434.00	231.40
HDFC Securities	950.00	300.00
ICICI Securities	1,546.90	417.96
Kotak Securities	NA	533.00
Spaisa	88.40	11.60
Anand Rathi	246.10	23.40

net profit to ₹735 crore. Revenue from operations rose 66 per cent to ₹1,501 crore, supported by higher operating leverage and increasing contributions from newer businesses such as margin trading facility (MTF) and commodity derivatives. EBITDA more than doubled to ₹971 crore during the quarter. A similar trend was visible across peers. Angel One's profit more than doubled to ₹231.4 crore on a 25.4 per cent increase in total income to ₹1,434 crore, aided by a record average client funding

book of ₹6,140 crore, up 46 per cent year-on-year. The company continued to benefit from strong retail participation, with its client base rising 19 per cent year-on-year to 3.86 crore. India's largest full-service retail brokerage, HDFC Securities, reported a 28 per cent increase in profit to ₹300 crore alongside 30 per cent revenue growth to ₹950 crore. Nearly 96 per cent of its 8 million customers transacted through digital platforms as the firm continued its shift towards lower-cost digital distribution. Kotak Se-

curities reported a net profit rise of 14.6 per cent to ₹533 crore, up from ₹465 crore a year earlier and ₹400 crore in the preceding quarter. ICICI Securities posted relatively stable earnings, with net profit rising 7 per cent to

₹417.96 crore from ₹389.51 crore a year ago, while revenue increased nearly 10 per cent to ₹1,546.9 crore. Digital brokerage 5 paisa reported 10 per cent growth in its average client funding book to ₹421.6 crore.

Vanchinad Finance Private Limited
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India bought record \$5.14 billion worth of Russian crude oil in June

STEADY RISE. New Delhi imported around 2.7 mb/d, accounting for more than half of its monthly imports

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Indian refiners bought record quantities of Russian crude oil, valued at more than \$5 billion, in June 2026 with Moscow transforming into New Delhi's strongest energy security hedge, particularly since the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) disruptions.

The Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA) in its latest commentary on Russia's earnings from its hydrocarbon trade pointed out that India imported €4.5 billion worth of crude oil in June, a growth of 32 per cent m-o-m and 25 per cent y-o-y.

The Jamnagar refinery saw the largest month-on-month rise in imported volumes of Russian crude (150 per cent month-on-month increase), followed by the Paradip (126 per



PRICE DIP. In June, the average price of Russia's Urals crude fell 26 per cent month-on-month to \$63.18 per barrel (STOCKPHOTO)

cent), Kochi (83 per cent) and Vadinar (45 per cent) refineries, it added.

TOP BUYER
India was again the second-largest buyer of Russian fossil fuels last month, importing a total of €5.5 billion (\$6.3 billion) of Russian hydrocarbons.

Crude oil constituted 83

per cent of India's purchases, totalling €4.5 billion (\$5.14 billion). Oil products (\$558 million) and coal (\$508 million) constituted the remainder of its monthly Russian imports.

In June, the average price of Russia's Urals crude fell 26 per cent month-on-month to \$63.18 per barrel, still signi-

The Jamnagar refinery saw the largest month-on-month rise in imported volumes of Russian crude

ficantly higher than the EU and UK price cap of \$44.1 per barrel, which took effect on 1 February 2026, CREA said.

As tanker traffic transporting fossil fuels through the Strait of Hormuz has increased significantly in June, oil prices declined amid market reassessment of the likelihood of sustained disruptions to oil flows, it added.

The price discount on Urals-grade crude oil relative to the global benchmark Brent remained flat at 28 per cent, or \$24 per barrel last month.

STEADY SUPPLIES
Russian barrels have enabled

Indian refiners to maintain high refinery run rates, ensure uninterrupted fuel supplies and avoid disruptions experienced by several other Asian refining systems (excluding China), added the real time data and analytics provider.

India imported around 2.7 million barrels per day (mb/d) of Russian crude oil in June, which is the highest on record and accounted for more than half of the country's cumulative monthly imports.

This growing importance is reflected in import trends, Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modeling, told *businessline* recently. "Russian crude imports rose to around 2.6 mb/d in June, accounting for more than 50 per cent of India's crude imports, and have been steadily increasing since March. July arrivals are also tracking at healthy levels and could match or even exceed June's volumes," he added.

TODAY'S PICK.

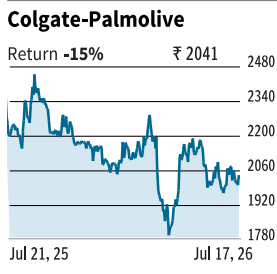
Colgate Palmolive (India) (₹2,041.95): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl, research bureau

The stock of Colgate Palmolive (India), although in a long-term downtrend, shows signs of a recovery, at least for the short-term. In April, it started the recovery on the back of the base at ₹1,780.

Following this, the price action since June, shows that the scrip has formed a higher base at ₹1,975. Although there is a resistance ahead at ₹2,100, we expect this to be invalidated.

This can trigger a fresh leg of rally to ₹2,200. Hence, there is a short-term buying opportunity here. We suggest buying now at ₹2,041 and accumulate at



₹1,990. Place stop-loss at ₹1,940. When the price rises to ₹2,100, raise the stop-loss to ₹2,040. On a rally to ₹2,150, tighten the stop-loss to ₹2,100. Book profits at ₹2,200.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading.

NITI Aayog to review industrial corridor framework

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government has launched a review of the institutional and implementation framework governing industrial corridors, industrial parks and integrated manufacturing ecosystems, seeking to identify bottlenecks and recommend reforms to accelerate project delivery and improve investor experience.

As part of the exercise, NITI Aayog will this week hold a stakeholder consultation to gather recommendations on policy, regulatory, institutional and

implementation changes needed to strengthen India's industrial competitiveness and support its goal of becoming a developed nation by 2047, sources said.

The review is being undertaken under the guidance of the High-Level Committee on Implementation of Viksit Bharat Goals (HLC-VB), chaired by NITI Aayog member Rajiv Gauba, which was constituted by the government to monitor key development programmes and infrastructure projects and recommend measures to speed up implementation.

The consultation will focus on project planning and land

development, regulatory and institutional reforms, project execution and delivery, connectivity and logistics, and improving investor experience and future readiness.

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AB PM-JAY's coverage reaches just 1.29 cr seniors prompting action

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Nearly two years after the Centre expanded the Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB PM-JAY) to cover all citizens aged 70 years and above, the scheme has reached only a fraction of its intended beneficiaries.

Of the six crore senior citizens eligible under the Ayushman Vayam Vandana Yojana, only about 1.29 crore have been approved for coverage, according to data available on the National Health Authority (NHA) dashboard. The dashboard also shows that around 1.2 crore beneficiaries have applied for Ayushman cards, while only 63,812 cards have been delivered. The rollout has been similarly slow for frontline workers. Of the 72.23 lakh ASHA workers, Anganwadi workers and Anganwadi helpers eligible under the scheme, coverage has been approved for only 44.1 lakh beneficiaries. Against this back-

drop, the National Health Authority (NHA) has asked States and Union Territories to prioritise enrolling all eligible beneficiaries under AB PM-JAY, expedite Ayushman Card generation, ensure complete coverage of ASHA workers, Anganwadi workers and Anganwadi helpers, and accelerate the implementation of the Ayushman Vayam Vandana Yojana for senior citizens.

The directions were issued during a two-day National Review Meeting (*Chintan Shivir*) organised by the NHA under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare to review the implementation of AB PM-JAY.

REVIEW MEETING

Inaugurating the meeting, Union Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare Prataprao Jadhav said the health insurance scheme had facilitated cashless treatment worth more than ₹1.91 lakh crore through over 37,000 empanelled hospitals.

The first day concluded with a presentation by AIIMS,

New Delhi, on its Clinical Decision Support System, which uses artificial intelligence to assist evidence-based clinical decision-making.

On the second day, the NHA recognised States and Union Territories for their performance. Andhra Pradesh, Sikkim and Lakshadweep received awards for issuing the highest number of Vay Vandana Scheme cards per lakh population in the large State, small State and Union Territory categories, respectively. Madhya Pradesh, Meghalaya and the Andaman & Nicobar Islands were honoured for the highest number of biometric-authenticated pre-authorisations.

businessline.

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HINDUSTAN POWER

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) For Supply, Erection, Testing, Commissioning and Civil Works for a Coal based Thermal Power Plant

Hindustan Powerprojects Pvt. Ltd. (HPPL) is developing an upcoming 800 MW coal based thermal power plant in the state of Madhya Pradesh, India. **HPPL invites Expressions of Interest (EOI)** from Indian and foreign companies for the supply and erection of equipment and execution of various Civil Works for the 800 MW coal based thermal power plant.

The EOI aims to identify experienced and financially sound companies/firms for inclusion in HPPL's vendor database for the supply and erection of the following equipment/systems or part thereof:

- Supply of major mechanical equipment/systems
- Supply of major electrical and instrumentation equipment/systems
- Civil Works
- Fabrication and supply of structural & miscellaneous steel works
- Boiler & Auxiliaries erection, Turbine-Generator & Auxiliaries erection, Electrical and Control & Instrumentation installation having experience for minimum 500 MW.
- Store Management for 1x800 MW supplies

Interested companies should visit our website at <https://hindustanpower.in/tenders> and email the duly filled EOI format available under the "EOI Supply, Erection, Testing, Commissioning and Civil Works" section.

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Web: www.elgi.com

NOTICE OF 66TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION

Notice is hereby given that the 66th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of ELGI Equipments Limited ("the Company") will be held through Video Conference ("VC") / Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM") facility on Friday, August 14, 2026 at 10:00 AM (IST) to transact the business(es) as set out in the Notice of the AGM dated May 27, 2026 in compliance with the Companies Act, 2013 ("the Act") and the rules framed thereunder and the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") read with the Circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") from time to time.

Further, in accordance with the MCA Circulars and Listing Regulations, the Notice of the AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 have been sent to all the Members whose e-mail ID is registered with the Company / Depositories as on July 17, 2026. The Company has dispatched the Notice of the AGM, along with the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26, on July 20, 2026.

The Notice of the AGM along with the explanatory statement and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26, is available and can be downloaded from the Company's website www.elgi.com and the website of Stock Exchanges on which the shares of the Company are listed i.e., BSE Limited and NSE National Stock Exchange of India Limited and on the website of MUFG Intime India Private Limited (Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited) ("MUFG") at <https://instavote.linkintime.co.in>.

Members can attend and participate in the AGM through VC / OAVM facility only by following the procedure as set out in the Notice of the AGM.

In compliance with applicable provisions of the Act, rules made thereunder and the Listing Regulations, the Members are provided with the facility to cast their votes on all resolutions as set forth in the Notice of the AGM using remote electronic voting system ("remote e-voting") provided by MUFG. Additionally, the Company is also providing the facility of voting through e-voting system during the AGM ("e-voting"). A detailed procedure for remote e-voting / e-voting is provided in the Notice of the AGM.

The Board of Directors of the Company have appointed Mr. M.D. Selvaraj, FCS, Managing Partner of MDS & Associates LLP, Company Secretaries as Scrutinizer to Scrutinize the voting process in a fair and transparent manner.

The remote e-voting commences from 9:00 AM (IST) on Tuesday, August 11, 2026 and ends at 5:00 PM (IST) on Thursday, August 13, 2026. The remote e-voting shall not be allowed beyond the said date and time and the module shall be disabled by the MUFG thereafter.

Those Members, who will be present at the AGM through VC / OAVM facility and had not cast their votes on the resolutions through remote e-voting and are otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting system during the AGM. A member may participate in the AGM even after exercising his / her right to vote through remote e-voting but shall not be allowed to vote again in the AGM.

A person whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in the Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the cut-off date i.e., Friday, August 7, 2026, shall only be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting or voting at the AGM. The voting rights of Members shall be in proportion to the shares held by them in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date.

Any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a Member of the Company after the Notice has been sent electronically by the Company, and holds shares as of the cut-off date, may obtain the login id and password by sending a request to enotices@in.mpbs.mufig.com. However, if he/she is already registered with MUFG for remote e-voting then he/she can use his/her existing User ID and Password for casting the votes.

In case the shareholder's email ID is already registered with the Company/its Registrar & Share Transfer Agent (RTA)/Depositories, log in details for e-voting are being sent on the registered email address. Shareholders holding shares in physical form or who have not registered their email address with the Company can cast their vote through remote e-voting or through the e-voting system during the AGM by following the procedure as set out in the Notice of AGM.

Shareholders who wish to register their email address may follow the below instructions:-

- Shareholders holding shares in demat form are requested to register/update the details in their demat account, as per the process advised by their respective depository participant.
- Shareholders holding shares in physical form are requested to register/update the details by filing the prescribed Form ISR-1 and other relevant forms with the Registrar and Transfer Agent of the Company, MUFG Intime India Private Limited (formerly Link Intime India Private Limited) at coimbatore@in.mpbs.mufig.com. Members may download the prescribed forms from the Company's website at www.elgi.com.

For details relating to remote e-voting, please refer to the Notice of the AGM, if you have any queries relating to remote e-voting, please refer the Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") and Instavote e-voting manual available at <https://instavote.linkintime.co.in> under Help Section or write an e-mail to enotices@in.mpbs.mufig.com or Call us at Tel: 022-49186000. In case of any grievances connected with facility for voting by electronic voting means, you can write an email to instameet@in.mpbs.mufig.com or call us at Tel: 022-49186175.

This public notice is also available in the Company's website viz. www.elgi.com and on the website of the stock exchanges where the shares of the Company are listed.

By Order of the Board
For **Elgi Equipments Limited**
Rohit Gupte
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer
Membership No.: A12422

July 20, 2026
Coimbatore

Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs
Government of India

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‘Textiles Min may open fresh PLI application window as relaxed norms draw interest’

RECOVERY PATH. Progress was initially slow due to the pandemic, says Textile Minister; inclusion of cotton apparel is ruled out for now

Amiti Sen
Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Textiles Ministry is planning to invite a fresh round of applications under its ₹10,683 crore Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme focussing on Man-Made Fibre (MMF) apparel, MMF fabrics and technical textiles to enable the industry to benefit from the relaxed investment and turnover criteria, Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh said.

“We have liberalised the investment criteria, reducing the investment thresholds to ₹150 crore and ₹100 crore. We are already

seeing strong participation from Madhya Pradesh and southern India. If required, we may open another window to encourage more applications,” Singh told *businessline*.

The scheme has so far seen three rounds of applications, with the last round closing in March this year. The government has approved 22 new applicants under round three of the PLI scheme for textiles. With this latest round of approvals, a total of 96 companies have now been selected with a cumulative committed investment of ₹12,822.67 crore and a projected turnover of ₹58,294.18 crore.

The PLI scheme for tex-



GROWTH INCENTIVE. The PLI scheme for textiles was launched in 2021 with an outlay of ₹10,683 crore REUTERS

tiles was launched in 2021 with an outlay of ₹10,683 crore, aimed at boosting domestic manufacturing of MMF apparel, MMF fabrics, and technical textiles, which

are segments where India has historically lagged behind competitors such as China, Vietnam, and Bangladesh, despite being one of the world’s largest

producers of cotton and natural fibres. Actual disbursements under the scheme have remained limited so far, as most approved units are still in the process of setting up operations or ramping up production.”

Disbursed provisional incentive of ₹54 crore to two applicants who completed their threshold investment and sales in FY25,” according to the 2025 year-end document of the Textiles Ministry.

Officials attribute the slow pace partly to the pandemic-induced disruptions in the initial years of the scheme, and partly to the typical two-year gestation period needed for such large manufacturing

projects to become fully operational. “Although we launched the PLI scheme in 2021, progress was initially slowed by the pandemic. It has since picked up pace, and we expect the registered units to be fully operational by 2027,” Singh said.

COTTON EXCLUDED

The earlier plan of widening the scheme to include apparel and garments made of cotton and other materials, however, seems to have been dropped by the Textiles Ministry. “The government’s focus is on promoting the man-made and technical textiles sector. That is where the huge untapped opportunity is,” a source said.

‘SEZ reforms panel to submit report soon’

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

A 17-member committee to suggest larger reforms in the policy for special economic zones (SEZs) will soon submit its report to the commerce ministry, an official said.

The report, which will be submitted to Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal, may include suggestions to revamp these zones to boost domestic manufacturing, exports and cut imports.

The committee has held meetings with stakeholders on the issues about these zones. The committee has focused on issues such as harmonisation of various prevalent export promotion schemes, including SEZs, export-oriented units (EoUs), MOOWR (Manufacturing

and Other Operations in Warehouse), Advance Authorisation, EPCG (Export Promotion for Capital Goods), and Duty-Free Import Authorisation. “The report will be submitted soon,” the official said. The terms of reference of the committee included identification of operational, procedural, and regulatory challenges faced by SEZ developers and units; reviewing the fiscal impact of SEZs and related reforms on revenue, including foregone duties and taxes; and assessing the cost-benefit outcomes in terms of exports, investment and economic activity.

It will recommend short-, medium- and long-term policy, legal and procedural reforms, including SEZ Act/ Rules amendments, and an implementation roadmap with timeline

‘Upcoming FTAs can create opportunities for Indian exporters’

bl.interview

Amiti Sen
Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The India-UK free trade agreement (FTA) has opened duty-free access for Indian textile and apparel exports to one of their key overseas markets, with more trade pacts expected to expand market access further.

Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh discusses the opportunities arising from India’s growing FTA network, the sector’s resilience amid global trade uncertainties, the spread of textile exports across 548 districts, and the government’s efforts to strengthen export facilitation and improve utilisation of free trade agreements.

Edited Excerpts:

The India-UK FTA came into effect on July 15. Textiles, apparel and clothing are among the sectors expected to benefit the most. What impact do you expect the agreement to have on the sector and its exports?

The biggest advantage of the FTAs that India is signing now, including the one with the UK, is the significant expansion of market access for Indian exporters. Earlier, our FTA network was relatively limited.

We had 10 FTAs covering 19 countries, with some agreements, particularly in Asia, covering multiple countries under a single pact.

As a result, our exporters had access to a much smaller set of markets.

Now, things are moving much faster and wider. The agreement with the UK has

come into force, negotiations with the European Union and New Zealand are almost ready to be implemented, and more agreements are in the pipeline. In the coming years, our FTA network is expected to cover 56 countries.

The global textile import market is worth around \$900 billion, and India’s share is only about 4 per cent.

Once the pending FTAs, including the one with the European Union, are concluded, these 56 countries will account for nearly 60 per cent of the global textile import market. That will create a significant opportunity for Indian exporters.

Even as India signs FTAs with developed economies, exporters face tariff uncertainty in the US market due to levies and ongoing investigations. How do

“The agreement with the UK has come into force; negotiations with the European Union and New Zealand are almost ready to be implemented, and more agreements are in the pipeline

GIRIRAJ SINGH
Textiles Minister



you see this affecting the sector, and what is the government’s strategy?

The US textile market itself is worth around \$90-100 billion.

Before 2024, India’s textile exports to the US were around \$10.9 billion. Despite the recent developments, we have managed to retain about 80 per cent

billion, but that did not happen. There was a decline, but the shortfall was around \$2 billion.

Necessity is the mother of invention, and we delivered.

What is the government doing to broaden textile export base and encourage more manufacturers to enter export markets?

India’s domestic market is very strong.

Our manufacturers have historically shown less interest in exports because of fears — a container getting returned, or uncertainty over whether quality compliance will hold up.

In the domestic market, there’s no such compliance pressure. Everything just moves.

But here’s the thing: across India, of all the registered exporters across all sectors combined, a sub-

stantial number are from our sector. Something special happened in our sector this time — exports took place from 548 districts.

Whether an individual export was worth ₹1 lakh or ₹1 billion, and whether it was handicraft, handloom, or garments, the encouraging fact is that the geographic spread reached 548 districts.

We currently have close to 60-70 centres under the Textile Department, the Textile Committee, and the Textile Commissioner. Right now, we’re developing six of these into dedicated Export Facilitation Centres — guiding new exporters on registration, documentation, and other basics. Going forward, I’ll be meeting the Chief Ministers of all States to highlight these 548 districts — asking them to have their District Magistrates reach out, recognise these exporters, boost their

morale, and work out which schemes can offer them incentives.

India has historically struggled with low utilisation of its FTAs. Will the proposed Export Facilitation Centres help exporters better understand the procedures such as obtaining Certificates of Origin, and enable them to make greater use of these agreements?

Exactly. That is why we are setting them up as Export Facilitation Centres.

They will guide exporters on the procedures and documentation required for exports, including issues related to FTAs. We have also directed all 11 Export Promotion Councils to conduct awareness programmes and actively bring smaller and regional businesses into the export ecosystem.

Afghanistan for stronger India ties and easier business access

Press Trust of India
Kabul

Afghanistan’s top trading body has called for expanding trade and investment ties with India, stressing the need to ease business procedures, remove administrative barriers and facilitate the issuance of business visas.

The proposals were discussed in Kabul during a meeting between Afghanistan Chamber of Commerce and Investment (ACCI) Chairman Sayed Karim Hashemi and Indian Ambassador to Afghanistan Yatin Patel.

The two sides held talks “in the framework of a strategic and diplomatic dialogue”, according to a statement released by the trading body.

The meeting comes amid a sharp decline in Afghanistan’s transit trade with neighbouring Pakistan, which fell to \$367 million in FY26 from about \$5 billion in FY21, as Kabul increasingly shifted to alternative trade routes, including through Iran. India has been strengthening connectivity with Afghanistan through Iran’s Chabahar port, which provides direct access to the landlocked country while bypassing Pakistan, which does not allow overland transit of Indian goods to Afghanistan.

India-Afghanistan bilateral trade stood at \$907.85 million in 2025-26.

India has also been stepping up engagement with Kabul, with Afghan Agriculture Minister Mawlawi Ataullah Omari visiting New Delhi earlier this month.

According to the ACCI statement, Hashemi reaffirmed the trading body’s commitment to strengthening long-term economic co-operation with India and highlighted the importance of facilitating trade procedures and institutional development in the private sector.

India, Spain to fast-track UPI-Bizum talks

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

India and Spain have agreed to fast-track discussions on enabling interoperability between Unified Payments Interface (UPI) and Spain’s Bizum digital payments plat-

form, the Commerce Ministry said on Sunday.

The two countries have also discussed ways to strengthen investment facilitation, improve mobility of professionals and promote joint investments in Latin America. These issues came up for discussion during the

recent visit of Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal to Spain.

“Both sides also agreed to advance technical discussions for interoperability between India’s UPI and Spain’s Bizum digital payments platform,” the ministry said.



Jinkushal Industries

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Email: info@jkpl.in, Website: www.jkpl.in

NOTICE TO MEMBERS OF JINKUSHAL INDUSTRIES LIMITED REGARDING 19TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING (AGM) AND E-VOTING INFORMATION:

1. Notice is hereby given that the 19th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of Jinkushal Industries Limited (Formerly Known as Jinkushal Industries Private Limited) ("the Company") will be held on Wednesday, 12th August, 2026 at Vimtara, Shanti Nagar, Indravati Colony, Raipur, Chhattisgarh 492001, India, in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and the Rules made thereunder and Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("LODR Regulations"), read with the General Circulars / Notifications issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and SEBI (collectively referred to as "applicable circulars"), to transact the business as set out in the Notice calling the AGM dated 18th July, 2026.

2. Pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 (as amended) and Regulation 44 of SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations 2015 (as amended) the Company is offering remote e-voting facility to all the respected members to enable them to cast their valuable vote on the Item of business to be transacted at the meeting.

3. Notice of EGM has been sent on 18th July, 2026 only through electronic mode to those Shareholders whose email ids are registered with the Company/ Depositories/ Depository Participants/ RTA and appearing as on Friday, 10th July, 2026.

4. Shareholders may note that Notice of AGM along with instructions for remote e-voting are also available on the Company's website www.jkpl.in/investors and on the website of stock exchange at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com

5. A person, whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date, i.e., **Wednesday 05th August, 2026** only shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting, and e-voting at AGM.

6. The Company is providing its members with the facility to exercise their right to vote on the resolutions proposed to be passed at the AGM by electronic means ("e-voting"). The Company has engaged the services of Bigshare Services Private Limited to provide the remote e-voting and e-voting facility. Members may cast their votes remotely through the electronic voting system available on the website of Bigshare Services Private Limited, the agency providing the remote e-voting and e-voting facility, at vote.bigshareonline.com.

7. The facility of e-voting shall be made available at the Meeting, and members attending the Meeting who have not cast their vote through remote e-voting shall be entitled to cast their vote at the Meeting through e-voting.

8. A member may exercise their voting right through only one mode of voting, i.e., either by remote e-voting or by e-voting at the meeting. If a member cast votes through both modes, the vote cast through remote e-voting shall prevail, and the vote cast through e-voting at the meeting shall be treated as invalid. Members who have cast their vote through remote e-voting or e-voting may attend the meeting; however, they shall not be entitled to vote again at the meeting.

9. Information and instructions including details of user-id and password relating to voting have been sent to the members through email. Members who do not receive email whose email addresses are not registered with the Company/RTA, may generate login credentials by following the instructions given in the 'Notes' forming part of the Notice convening the AGM.

a. The remote e-voting facility will be available during the following period:

Commencement of remote e-voting	Saturday 08th August, 2026 9:00 AM
End of remote e-voting	Tuesday 11th August, 2026 till 5:00 PM

b. The remote e-voting module shall be disabled by Big Share Services Private Limited for voting thereafter. The Members, whose names appear in the Register of Members/Beneficial Owners as on the record date (cut-off date) i.e., Wednesday 05th August, 2026 may cast their vote electronically.

10. Manner of registering/updating email id with the Company/ Depositories:

a. For Demat shareholders - Please update your email id & mobile no. with your respective Depository Participant (DP).

b. For Individual Demat shareholders-Please update your email id & mobile no. with your respective Depository Participant (DP) which is mandatory while e-voting.

All grievances connected with the facility for voting by electronic means may be addressed to Big Share Services Private Limited through an email lvote@bigshareonline.com or at the toll-free no.: 08069219070

Annual Report for the FY 2025-26
accessed Below QR



For Jinkushal Industries Limited
Sd/- Manish Tarachand Pandey
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
Membership No. A48185

Place: Raipur
Date: 19.07.2026



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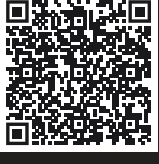
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A CH-CHE

QUICKLY.

Policy review: Comm Secy to visit Geneva

New Delhi: Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal is visiting Geneva this week for India's eighth trade policy review report, an official said. The secretary is leading a team of Indian officials to the headquarters of the World Trade Organisation (WTO), the official said. The report will be released this month. Such reports include detailed chapters examining the trade policies and practices of the member. It also includes trade policymaking institutions and a country's macroeconomic situation. The objectives of the review include facilitating the smooth functioning of the multilateral trading system. PTI

Correction

In the article 'The simple and complex of I-T' (July 19, 2026), it was erroneously mentioned that Schedule AL kicks in above ₹50 lakh of income. The threshold was enhanced to ₹1 crore from AY26. The error is regretted.

Monsoon ‘low’ weakens, but signals heavy rain for N. West, Central India

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

The low-pressure area that triggered the monsoon's second revival has weakened, but not before setting the stage for another week of heavy to very heavy rainfall across North-West and Central India, with the west coast also getting a share of the action.

The fresh spell comes even as India's monsoon deficit has widened to 24 per cent as of Friday. East and North-East India remain the driest, with a 36 per cent shortfall, followed by the South Peninsula (28 per cent), North-West India (24 per cent); and Central India (13 per cent).

EMERGING WET PHASE
Forecast models indicate that the upcoming wet phase will focus on North-West and Central India. Among the cities likely in the firing line are Bhopal, Indore, Damoh and Guna in Madhya Pradesh; Kota in East Rajasthan; Bareilly in West Uttar Pradesh; Haldwani in Uttarakhand; Mandi, Dharamshala and Chamba in Himachal Pradesh; and Pathankot, Doda, Udhampur and Billawar in Jammu & Kashmir.

SOUTH MAY SIT OUT
In contrast, the South Peninsula, fringes of West Rajasthan, and large parts of Maharashtra are expected to miss out on this rainy surge. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued a broadly similar outlook. It has warned of heavy to very heavy rain, with isolated extremely heavy falls

Naveen Jindal Group in talks with global nuclear tech providers

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Naveen Jindal Group has initiated discussions with global nuclear technology providers including France-based EDF and Westinghouse of the US for its proposed nuclear power projects in India, a person in the know said.

The Group is also in discussions with state-owned Nuclear Power Corporation of India to explore possibilities of sourcing technology for future nuclear projects with large module reactors of 700 MW and above.

The steel-to-ports conglomerate plans to develop around 18 GW of nuclear power capacity across multiple states with an estimated investment of ₹2 lakh crore, contributing to the government's target of achieving 100 GW of nuclear power capacity by 2047.

PNB hopeful of achieving net interest margin, FCNR (B) targets

CAUTIOUS MOVE. Deposit growing lower than credit is not a concern, says MD and CEO Ashok Chandra

bl.interview

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Despite a growth of just over 2 per cent in net interest income in the first quarter, Punjab National Bank's MD and CEO Ashok Chandra, is confident of achieving a 7 per cent growth in FY27. Talking to *businessline*, he said deposit growing lower than credit is not a concern. Excerpts:

What are the new initiatives to achieve the target of \$2.5 billion through FCNR (B) deposits by September 30, 2026?

One is connecting with the NRIs. We have a large franchise and good NRI base. We have started connecting all tools.

We are explaining this product. Reaching out to the people is one important strategy, and second is ex-

plaining the benefits that NRIs can derive from this. We are hopeful of achieving the target.

You have given a guidance of 7 per cent for growth related to Net Interest Income (NII). However, growth during the first quarter was 2.1 per cent. How are you going to achieve this?

We have started building good quality credit book now and we have come out from the challenge of having low-holding advances. Cost of deposit has started coming down. Mobilisation of FCNR (B) deposit will reduce the cost of deposit because whatever we are going to mobilise, it will not carry the CRR-SLR purpose.

To that extent, the cost of deposit will come down. We are working on both the front — cost of deposit and yield on advances and I am expecting that good growth should happen on the NII



We have started building good quality credit book now and we have come out from the challenge of having low-holding advances.

ASHOK CHANDRA,
MD & CEO, Punjab National Bank



front from now onwards.

Guidance for operating profit is 9-10 per cent while growth during first quarter was 6.2 per cent. How are you going to achieve the guidance for operating profit?

Last year, the bank initiated three new activities — the supply chain vertical, cash management services and credit card, and these three activities have started picking up very well in this financial year.

For all three verticals, we have revenue targets. Second is the rejigging of the balance sheet which we have done, the low-yielding advances and all which we have said. It will also add to the profitability of the bank.

The operating profit also will go up. And third, there has been muted recovery in the first quarter which is expected to improve. With all this we have said that at least 9-10 per cent growth should happen in the operating profit.

Your net profit surged over three times in the first quarter and one reason is that last year your tax outgo was very high in the corresponding quarter. However, on a sequential basis, the growth in net profit appears to have plateaued. Is it so?

No. In fact, we are making some additional cushion like ₹390 crore for the ECL provision in this quarter.

It is a floating provision we have kept and the entire floating provision as of today is ₹2,435 crore. This we have started doing from Q2 onwards last year and we have built a very substantial provision.

Now all these things will help us in migration, that will happen from the first of April 2027.

If I would have added this in my net profit, it would have been more than ₹5,700 crore. If the opportunity is

We are very mindful of raising the deposit in the bulk segment or in the CD market. It is not that we are not getting the deposits, they are available.

there, why not keep it for the future when the migrations and the challenges are going to happen, so that there should be smooth transition.

Another important aspect, is the first quarter of the last year was challenging because of the migration from old tax to new tax regime and that was an aberration.

Otherwise, Q2, Q3, Q4 and this quarter, there has been substantial improvements. The bank is consistent in managing these things and we will deliver the fig-

ures like this in the future too.

Deposit growth is lower than credit growth in your guidance too, is this a concern?

It is not a concern at all. We have a deposit growth of 8.5 per cent and credit growth of 12.7 per cent in Q1, still my CD ratio is 73.4 per cent. This means we have enough room with this growth to reach a level of 77-78 per cent and then only we need to think of growing at a faster speed. But we will be restricting ourselves to grow at 9 per cent, for which we have given the guidance.

We are very mindful of raising the deposit in the bulk segment or in the CD market. It is not that we are not getting the deposits, they are available.

However, they come at a cost and if that is not helping me in getting the good reward out of that mobilisation, we are not interested in mobilising such deposits.

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3.	https://t.me/SkyPay365	10.	https://t.me/WinGo555
4.	https://t.me/Invesco88	11.	https://t.me/InvescoBot
5.	https://t.me/Invescomutual	12.	https://t.me/Invesco_bot
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(Investment Manager for Invesco Mutual Fund)

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Systemic cancer

India’s cancer burden needs a public health response

India is staring at a cancer crisis of catastrophic proportions. ICMR’s National Cancer Registry Programme estimates nearly 15.7 lakh new cancer cases in 2025, a number projected by the International Agency for Research on Cancer to rise to over 22.2 lakh by 2040. As incidence climbs with toxic air and food, lifestyle changes and ageing population, cancer has become a huge public health challenge — as well as an exceptionally lucrative business.

An analysis by this newspaper of the revenues of India’s largest hospital chains showed that between 17 and 25 per cent of hospital revenues now come from oncology. At Max Healthcare, cancer care accounted for over 25 per cent of inpatient revenues in the first nine months of FY26, generating roughly ₹1,560 crore. Apollo Hospitals derived around 17 per cent of its hospital revenues, nearly ₹1,900 crore, from oncology in FY25. Unsurprisingly, smaller hospital groups are racing to establish oncology centres. The rush reflects not merely rising demand but the realisation that cancer care has become one of the most profitable segments in private healthcare. Significantly, doctors believe that despite proliferation of large and small dedicated hospitals, the demand is still under-served. For patients, however, the economics is devastating. A rough estimate of routine treatment comes at a steep price with one chemotherapy cycle in a private hospital costing ₹30,000 to ₹2 lakh, radiation therapy ₹2-5 lakh, cancer surgery ₹3-10 lakh, targeted therapies and immunotherapy ₹1-4 lakh and bone marrow transplants ₹15-40 lakh. Over 70 per cent of patients require more than one type of treatment so even with insurance, families increasingly find their cover exhausted during a single episode of treatment. Public healthcare urgently needs to step up. The reality is that — taking the example of Delhi alone — even premier institutions like AIIMS are overwhelmed.

Global experience suggests that unless healthcare is taken up as the state’s responsibility, a vast majority suffers for lack of access and resources. The government claims that between 2013-14 and 2022-23, the share of Out of Pocket Expenditure in total health expense has gone down from 64.2 per cent to 43.4 per cent. Analysts have observed that Centre and States spend less than 2 per cent of GDP on health. The National Health Policy 2017 had aimed at raising spending on public health to 2.5 per cent of GDP. With commercialisation of critical care, people are being pushed into poverty, indebtedness and most crucially, preventable deaths. India’s growing cancer burden requires a policy shift that treats cancer care as a public responsibility. The state must step in, not merely as an insurer, but as a provider of accessible, affordable and high-quality healthcare. Meanwhile, private insurance packages for cancer, a mushrooming sector, must be monitored for premiums charged and reimbursement — even as complaints on this score abound.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Political poetry must become governing prose
Andy Burnham is finally Labour leader. After trying – and failing – twice to be elected by party members, he took the top job on Friday without a contest. Sir Keir Starmer remains prime minister until Monday, when he will tender his resignation to King Charles, who will invite Mr Burnham to form a government. Then the future that Mr Burnham has long imagined will cease to be a promise and become a test. Much will be written about the man. But why does Mr Burnham believe what he believes? One clue lies in the Guardian’s letters page in 1991. Fresh from graduating in English at Cambridge, the 21-year-old Mr Burnham defended an “uncouth and uncultured” Philip Larkin from critics who dismissed him as “too parochial”. LONDON, JULY 17

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The SAVE America Act Backfire
President Trump broke into prime-time TV on Thursday night to talk to the nation about election security, but it must have been a letdown for anybody expecting a thrilling plot twist in Mr. Trump’s long yarn about his 2020 defeat. Instead he made a sales pitch for a bill that can’t pass, using doubts it wouldn’t address. Mr. Trump released documents that he said show vulnerabilities in U.S. election systems, and some of them are real, though they run the gamut. He said voter files on millions of people, including names, addressees and party affiliations, “have been bought, stolen or hacked by China.” A 2020 intelligence memo advised that adversaries “have the capability to compromise” election infrastructure, especially “registration databases, pollbooks, and official election websites.” NEW YORK, JULY 18

So the world is back where it started in the US-Iran war. After a short lived ceasefire, both sides are bombing each other. The flow of crude oil is disrupted and global supply is likely to remain below demand for a long time to come, the IMF thinks. Soon after Donald Trump attacked Iran, I had written about how, in history, we find that from time to time eccentric people come to power and change the world forever by their unilateral actions. But there has never been a time when three such people were at it simultaneously. The three are Donald Trump, Xi Jinping and Vladimir Putin. These three guys don’t seem to care a fig about what they do to the world and their own countries. They are eccentric (or worse) in every sense of the word. Thus, Trump and Putin have gone to wars which they have lost but are banging on regardless. Xi has managed to unite the world against China in a way that will eventually wreck the Chinese economy. This process has already begun as the rest of the world starts to make alternative arrangements for trade and security. The silver lining is that Trump will go in January 2029 when, hopefully, America will get a more reasonable president. But let that not obscure the scary fact that Trump is there for two-and-half years more. He has already created massive havoc in the 18 months he has been President. He could still, and will, do untold damage. And Xi and Putin are there for life and have the power to wreak further havoc in pursuit of their megalomaniacal agendas. Of the three, Putin is the weakest but even he is no slouch in terms of military strength. Xi and Trump have military power as well as economic strength. America is about 20 years ahead of these two in terms of technology.

WAGES OF MEGALOMANIA
What we are looking at is exactly the kind of thing George Orwell had predicted in his classic book, 1984, where there are three major groups engaged in an unending fight to the finish. They just go on and on and on until no one even asks what it’s all about. None of these three has any reason whatsoever to behave in this destructive fashion. America was powerful and still is. Russia has the oil and gas that the rest of the world needs. And China controls



The world’s set for a bumpy ride

Trump, Xi and Putin’s actions will cause turmoil in world economy going ahead. India will have to take some tough calls on the revenue front

industrial production for much of the world. The three between them had enough muscle to get whatever they wanted without going to war. Yet Russia and America have done so. China had the goodwill and money to impose its will and it’s probably only a matter of time before it tries something in Taiwan. What is different this time is that such power struggles which involved the None of these three leaders has any reason to behave in this destructive fashion. US was powerful and still is. Russia has the oil and gas that the rest of the world needs. And China controls industrial production for much of the world

whole world started in Europe or were started by European powers. This time around Europe is as much a victim as all others are. But the consequences are the same: global disruption, destruction and devastation. And unlike in the past since these three men aren’t fighting each other directly, and two of them are there for life, there’s no saying when all this nonsense will stop. But we can be certain about one thing: it won’t be soon. **INDIA’S PROBLEMS** And so, as always, we come to India. Like the rest of the world we are in for a very bumpy ride economically. This could last, at the very least, until January 20, 2029. But the chances are that as America fights to retain its number one position, it will last well beyond. Therefore, it is now widely expected that world economic activity and growth will shrink. As global growth falters, it will put pressure on Indian government revenues as well which will have to continue to subsidise welfare

programmes, pay wage bills and pensions and fund defence expenditure, not to mention interest on past debt. There is already the possibility of a supplementary demand for grants in the monsoon session, the first in five years. So, once the efforts at better collections from existing taxpayers reach their limits, expect higher taxes in the future. This will probably happen from 2027 onwards. I think the free ride that companies have been getting since 2018 is also getting over. Personal income taxes, too, will be revised upwards and GST exemptions, devised for political reasons, will now be revised downwards. In overall fiscal management terms governments the world over will lean towards demand management via a combination of rationing and the price mechanism. The silver lining is that our governments are masters of that art. They even excel in saying no to citizens about whether they are citizens. So I guess we will be fine.

Balancing energy security, environmental concerns

Coal gasification scheme strengthens import security, but it will lead to huge carbon emissions that need to be managed

Aditi Nayar
In May 2026, as the West Asia crisis was unfolding, the Union Cabinet of India approved a ₹375-billion incentive scheme for surface coal and lignite gasification projects. This move makes coal gasification a key policy instrument in India’s effort to convert its large domestic coal base into strategic industrial feedstocks, reducing the dependence on imports. Unlike conventional coal combustion, where coal is burned primarily to release energy, gasification uses controlled oxygen and steam at high temperature and pressure to convert coal into synthesis gas, or syngas. This syngas can then be used to produce ammonia, urea, methanol, synthetic natural gas, hydrogen, liquid fuels and even power through integrated gasification combined cycle plants. India has coal resources of around 400 billion tonnes and 47 billion tonnes of lignite reserves, placing it among the five largest coal-resource holders globally. At the same time, India remains heavily dependent on imports for several key molecules. As of fiscal 2025, ammonia was fully imported, methanol imports account for nearly 90 per cent of domestic needs, natural gas imports are around half of consumption, and urea imports account for about one-fifth of demand.

Since syngas can be converted into ammonia, urea, methanol and synthetic natural gas, coal gasification provides a domestic route to substitute part of these imports and reduce exposure to global price and supply volatility. The new scheme marks a fourfold increase over the ₹85 billion coal gasification scheme launched in January 2024 that had targeted around 25 projects. It aims to support gasification of about 75 million tonnes of coal by 2030 and offers incentives of up to 20 per cent of plant and machinery costs, paid in milestone-linked instalments. It is also supported by coal linkage reforms extending raw-material security for select projects for up to 30 years. The programme is also expected to attract investments of around ₹2.5-3.0 trillion and generate nearly 50,000 direct and indirect jobs, underscoring the government’s intent to create an integrated domestic coal-to-chemicals ecosystem alongside reducing import dependence. For India, the relevance extends beyond energy security. Gasification offers a pathway to utilise domestic coal as an industrial raw material for fertilizers, chemicals and synthetic fuels, particularly as the share of coal consumed in power generation gradually declines with increasing renewable-energy penetration. Discouragingly, this supply chain security comes at a cost. Both natural



COAL GASSIFICATION. Reducing energy imports

gas and coal-derived syngas are used to produce hydrogen, which is required for the manufacture of fertilizers such as urea, ammonia, ammonium nitrate, and fuels such as methanol and Dimethyl Ether (DME). **EMISSION WORRIES** However, producing hydrogen from coal generates approximately twice as much carbon dioxide (CO₂) as producing it from natural gas, which remains the dominant production route among India’s suppliers. Replacing imports of LNG, urea, ammonia and methanol through the coal-to-syngas route could substitute roughly \$14-15 billion of annual imports. But such a transition could increase CO₂ emissions from around 47-52 million tonnes under the current import-based supply chain to 106-111 million tonnes annually, at odds with India’s plans to curtail emissions.

Hence, while the programme has the potential to strengthen energy and feedstock security, its long-term sustainability will depend on the ability to manage the associated carbon footprint. As a result, Carbon Capture, Utilisation and Storage (CCUS) will be indispensable to India’s coal gasification ambitions. With domestic production through the coal-to-syngas route potentially increasing emissions, India would need to capture and utilise an additional 55-60 million tonnes of CO₂ every year to neutralise the environmental impact. The scale of this challenge is significant because India’s CCUS ecosystem remains at an early stage, with only three operational carbon capture projects and six projects currently under construction, highlighting the need for rapid capacity expansion. Coal gasification therefore represents both an opportunity and a test. It offers a pathway to convert India’s vast domestic coal reserves into valuable industrial feedstocks, reduce import dependence and support economic growth. But its success will ultimately be judged not only by the imports it replaces, but also by how effectively it addresses the environmental challenge that accompanies this transformation.

The writer is Chief Economist, Head- Research & Outreach, ICRA

● BELOW THE LINE



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk at Jantar Mantar

Slogan circus
As the battle over the Jantar Mantar protests spilled from the streets to social media, the slogan circus proved as entertaining as it was revealing. The day before activist Sonam Wangchuk’s eviction, the sudden appearance of several television crews set tongues wagging. The online spectacle soon eclipsed the protest itself. One pro-establishment YouTuber persuaded a Buddhist monk to recite

the *Gayatri Mantra*. The monk responded with a patient smile. Elsewhere, an apparent bid to provoke protesters by shouting ‘*Har Har Mahadev*’ took an unexpected turn when the crowd, which had been chanting ‘*Jai Bhim*’, simply joined in with ‘*Har Har Mahadev*’. The script, it seemed, had gone awry, leaving the slogan circus to play out more on screens than on the streets. **Transfer sagas** It has been a week of small political comedies. The recent transfer of four close aides of Union Minister Bhupender Yadav, including his private secretary and three additional private secretaries, has set Delhi’s rumour mills spinning, with the official explanation stopping at “administrative grounds”. Another tale doing the rounds in bureaucratic circles was a district collector who was reportedly

expected to be transferred before the Prime Minister’s visit was instead seen receiving him at an official function, prompting speculation. The whisper network claims the transfer was stalled after the intervention of a ministerial staffer, allegedly using the minister’s name. In Delhi, every transfer order seems to acquire a life, and a backstory, of its own. **Village makeover** Chudel village in Gujarat’s Surat district — whose name, in common parlance, is associated with a “witch” in Indian folklore — has officially been renamed Chandanpur. The change follows approval from the Union Home Ministry, after which the Gujarat government directed all departments to update official records. The State government, however, has not cited any reason for the renaming.

With that, one of Gujarat’s most unusual village names will gradually disappear from maps, signboards and government records, replaced by the decidedly more understated Chandanpur. Other than the name, little else seems to have changed in this village in Mandvi taluka. **Caught in a bind** Late last week, the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy said that a limited window is being provided for Net-metering projects and Open Access RE power projects, whereby such projects can now commission with exemption of Approved List of Models & Manufacturers (ALMM) List-II (for solar PV cells), till December 31, 2026. It, however, stressed that there will be no change in the government policy in respect of implementation of ALMM List-II for solar PV cells, and no blanket extension in applicability of ALMM

List-II for solar power projects will be provided. Earlier this dispensation for the limited segment of Net-metering projects and Open Access renewable power projects, was available till May 31, 2026. This, according to them, will also help the standalone solar PV module manufacturers by providing them protection of investments already made, in the form of inventories, through additional demand creation. This will also provide them sufficient time before they could effectively increase their sourcing of solar cells from ALMM List-II enlisted. Critics are questioning the timing. Is the government caught in a bind? Seems so, as an industry tracker said: “they are unable to do away with the policy and smaller players are facing the brunt as they are unable to meet the requirements of the policy.” **Our Bureaus**

Hidden life of trees

A valuable deep ecology work on nurturing trees

BOOK REVIEW.

Sudhirendar Sharma

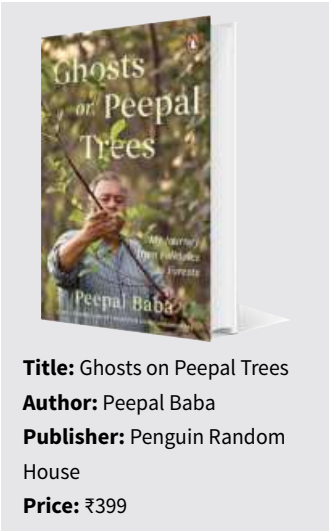
Some trees have stood beyond their botanical existence as emblems of profound human experience and milestones. Amongst them, an apple tree inspired Isaac Newton to formulate his theory of gravity and a peepal tree helped Gautama Buddha attain enlightenment. These iconic trees continue to stand as a living testimony to pivotal moments in history.

All trees stand at the juncture of science and spirituality, and ecology and eternity. Who else would know it better than Peepal Baba, who got a popular identity for his relentless campaign in planting and nurturing millions of trees over the past five decades. *Ghosts on Peepal Trees* is the memoir of Swami Prem Parivartan, *alias* Peepal Baba, which offers an absorbing tutorial on every aspect of trees, from seed to shade.

Drawn from handwritten notes and scattered observations written over years, the author pools together the stories of his intense engagement with a wide diversity of trees in his journey across the country's 21 States and 226 districts. Under the aegis of *Give Me Trees*, a movement was generated as an act of eco-philosophy — ‘we inhale what the trees exhale, and humans live because trees exist’. Trees have existed long before humans and may do so till all lifeform persists.

At a time when the development juggernaut is destroying trees to erect concrete jungles, planting and nurturing trees can be a humble vocation that can be pursued by right-minded people. It is not just a hobby but a vocation that connects science with spirituality. *Ghosts on Peepal Tree* is more than a memoir, it is a transformative narrative that connects and inspires. It educates the reader that a tree is a living piece of ecological infrastructure, that offers free climate regulation and biodiverse services.

SCIENCE OF TREES
While the peepal as a tree is revered, the awe for the species is based on scientific facts. It is perhaps the only tree species that emits oxygen during night. Unlike other trees, the peepal doesn't rest. A special adaptation measure called Crassulacean Acid Metabolism helps absorb carbon dioxide during night. As the sun rises the next day, this stored carbon dioxide is used for



Title: Ghosts on Peepal Trees
Author: Peepal Baba
Publisher: Penguin Random House
Price: ₹399

photosynthesis. This makes peepal scientifically extraordinary, a keystone species in the tropical ecosystem.

In addition, it absorbs as much as 20 kg of carbon dioxide during the year and releases no less than 300 litres of oxygen daily. Not only that, this tree is distinct for its ability in combining three types of rooting systems that makes it a living cathedral of wood and wisdom, sustaining under diverse situations.

Influenced by the teachings of Osho, the author dismantles many myths around trees with logically argued facts. The book celebrates trees as natural creativity. The myth about ghosts on peepal were actually lessons in how faith protects forests. It further proves how simple acts of care protect trees, even in the absence of formal mechanisms or structures. These messages reach out to millions through the author's social media platforms.

Ghosts on Peepal Trees is a veritable treatise on trees, that cultivates empathy and sensitivity towards trees. Walking under the canopy of trees, little does one realise that one is walking under a cathedral of oxygen. Each story in the book reads like a research paper. It connects with the virtues of trees, and inspires the reader into the act of nurturing trees. It is experiential writing at its best, educating and inspiring. It is more than a book of stories.

The stories in the book are symbols of our existence, woven through our culture, scriptures, myths and memories. The book helps us fall in love with biodiversity, and to take small steps that generate greenery. In the author's words: ‘It is a memoir of exploration, of ghosts and angels, of trees and teachers, and of the quiet miracle of existence’.

The reviewer is an independent writer, researcher and academic

A searing expose of ‘modern slavery’

This book tells the story of the H-1B visa and how it was misused to exploit IT workers both Indian and American

BOOK REVIEW.

Sanjana B

Every fairy tale follows a format: a protagonist, a magical journey, a conflict with a villain, and a triumph of good over evil that ends in a “happily ever after”.

The magical journey most Indians dream of is the one to America. The “happily ever after” is being “well settled in America”, which naturally makes an H-1B applicant the protagonist.

If the plot is laid out cleanly, then where is the conflict? And who is the villain? *Wild Wild East* by independent journalist and film critic Tanul Thakur exposes a controversial nexus involving IT behemoths, outsourcing giants, visa mills, and *desi* consultancies that power what he terms “modern slavery”.

In the book's introduction, Thakur recounts studying electrical engineering at the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (UIUC) in 2010, anxious about finding a job within three months of graduation.

He received a call one day offering him an IT position at a Fortune 500 company, with a \$60,000 annual salary and the golden ticket — an H-1B visa. Thakur chose to hang up. Millions of other Indians, however, took the bait.

THE DIFFERENT ROUTES
In what reads like an anthology, Thakur narrates the stories of three real people whose lives were inevitably affected by the H-1B programme — Virgil Bierschwale, a Texas-based Navy veteran trying to break into America's IT scene, and Hyderabad natives PK Sreenivas, also known as Kumar Pandravad, and Manu Mitra. Kumar pursued the direct route, applying for an

H-1B visa in 2008 and securing approval after multiple rejections. He was then recruited by a New Jersey-based IT firm, 4M TechGroup, with an annual salary of \$55,000. Manu, meanwhile, chose the F-1 student visa route, enrolling at the University of Bridgeport, a private university in Connecticut.

However, the duo's American dream quickly turned sour. Over the next decade, Kumar and Manu encountered the exploitation that, Thakur argues, underpins parts of the H-1B ecosystem. Central to this is the “*desi* consultancy” — an IT body shop typically owned by and catering largely to Indians — which Thakur describes as operating like a “cult”.

According to Thakur, some of these consultancies inflate candidates' resumes to exaggerate their experience, arrange proxy interviews in which another person, usually from the consultancy, answers technical questions on a candidate's behalf, and coach applicants during video interviews by feeding them responses off-camera or via IMs. Thakur also notes that some offshore branches in India use services like MagicJack to obtain US phone numbers and adopt American aliases to pose as local recruiters to trap unsuspecting job applicants.

For example, a 70-30 per cent ratio means an employee gets 70 per cent of the billing rate and 30 per cent goes to the employer. An ideal project involving a *desi* consultancy employer looks like this — H-1B Worker -> Employer -> Prime vendor -> Client. In reality, one or more middle vendors are often inserted between the employer and the prime vendor.

According to Thakur, such middle vendors insert themselves into the food chain in various ways — through employers routing contracts via associates, recruiters inserting themselves into existing job postings, or



Title: Wild Wild East
Author: Tanul Thakur
Publisher: Westland/Context
Price: ₹999

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Tanul Thakur is an award-winning journalist and film critic. In 2015, he won the National Film Award for Best Film Critic — the youngest critic to receive the honour

hiring managers colluding with middle vendors. Each additional layer takes a cut of the billing rate, reducing the worker's final earnings.

Thakur also argues that large Indian IT outsourcing firms have played a significant role in the exploitation of this H-1B programme, citing multiple examples of accusations of visa fraud and wage and hour violations.

Meanwhile, these forces also shaped the lives of local Americans like Virgil — both White and people of colour —

many of whom remained unemployed for years. Thakur argues that they were sidelined by a system that overwhelmingly favoured Indian workers, who were “less fussy and demanding”.

At the same time, he explains that many H-1B holders faced exploitation of their own, often receiving no pay for months, being benched for ages without clarity, earning below-market wages, and working long hours.

Wild Wild East is a shocking revelation for many Indians whose aspirations are tied to securing an H-1B visa and building a life in the US. Thakur weaves together the philosophies and experiences of an American worker displaced by the outsourcing ecosystem and two H-1B holders caught within it. The result is a much-needed and timely examination today of India's enduring belief that success lies in making it abroad.

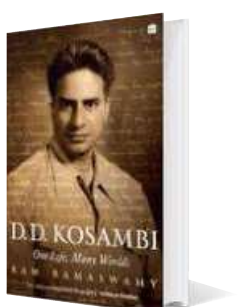
Eventually, the rose-tinted glasses through which Manu and Kumar viewed America come off — and so do the readers'.

Many Indian professionals grow up inspired by the success of the Pichais, the Nadellas, and the Krishnas; that with an American degree, a dollar salary, and an American dream, they too would become the CEO of a multinational IT giant.

Instead, Thakur argues that this dream is upheld by a system that prioritises corporate profitability, exploits gaps in immigration rules and relies on a workforce willing to endure long hours, uncertain employment and limited bargaining power in pursuit of a better future.

Wild Wild East is a must-read for people harbouring this dream — whether H-1B aspirants, their families, or those who want to understand the realities behind one of India's most heralded pathways to success.

NEW READS.

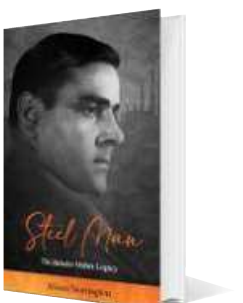


Title: D.D. Kosambi: One Life, Many Worlds

Author: Ram Ramaswamy

Publisher: HarperCollins

This biography reveals a rare incandescent genius whose relevance in the fields of pedagogy, research and invention can be seen even today

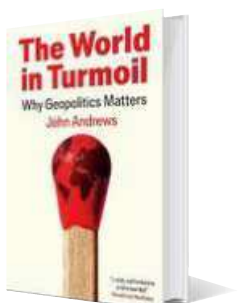


Title: Steel Man: The Jatinder Mehra Legacy

Author: Alison Norrington

Publisher: Penguin Enterprise

Jatinder Mehra's name is etched into the foundations of India's steel industry. This book captures his milestones and wisdom imparted



Title: The World in Turmoil: Why Geopolitics Matters

Author: John Andrews

Publisher: Economist Books

The long view of factors that influence politics, untangling complex threads that both bind us and threaten to tear us apart

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

July 20, 2006

Re hits 3-year low on oils concerns

The rupee plunged to a three-year low to 46.99/77 against the US dollar on Wednesday as domestic oil companies bought large amount of dollars in view of soaring crude oil prices. Forex dealers said appreciation of the dollar against other overseas currencies also aided the rupee's fall.

IB may vet Net telephony applications

New applications from companies wanting a licence for offering internet telephony in the country may be scrutinised by the Intelligence Bureau. This comes after the vigilance section of the Department of Telecom found that the network of some Internet Service Providers (ISPs) were allegedly being used for carrying international long-distance calls illegally.

‘Waive capital gains tax for VCFs exiting from unlisted cos’

Venture capital funds (VCFs) exiting unlisted companies may get capital gains exemption, if the recommendations of a committee appointed by the Planning Commission is accepted by the Government. “We see no logic in VCFs getting less favourable tax treatment on their exits from unlisted companies,” said Mr Nitin Desai, Chairman of the Committee.

Short take

Role of trust in financial governance

Arun Raste

For decades, financial governance was largely synonymous with compliance.

That paradigm, while necessary, is no longer sufficient. The world that organisations operate in today is volatile, shaped by technological disruption, stakeholder activism and unprecedented transparency.

Historically the Chief Financial Officer (CFO) is tasked with being a custodian — maintaining accounting integrity, cost management and regulatory compliance. AI and advanced analytics are reinventing the CFO's role, with governance moving to the forefront

of financial leadership. So the modern CFO has to: Provide Strategic advice to the CEO and the board; Translate data into actionable insights; Act as a steward of organisational trust; Manage capital allocation in volatile environments; Anchor risk management frameworks across the enterprise.

For organisations, this transition means: Redefining competency frameworks for finance leaders; investing in digital and analytical capabilities within finance teams; creating governance structures where finance drives – not follows – strategy

Modern governance frameworks need to leverage risk identification with predictive analytics.

Trust has become the most valuable

intangible asset in an increasingly connected world that explicitly links governance with trust, compliance and strategic value creation. In commodity markets, where farmers, traders and institutions interact, trust plays an even more important role in ensuring inclusive participation.

Governance does not merely have to meet minimum compliance anymore. Governance now focuses on sustainability and value.

Technology has a critical role to play in the upcoming transformation of financial governance. The integration of AI and Analytics will enhance risk modelling and support faster, more intelligent governance decisions. Blockchain and distributed ledger

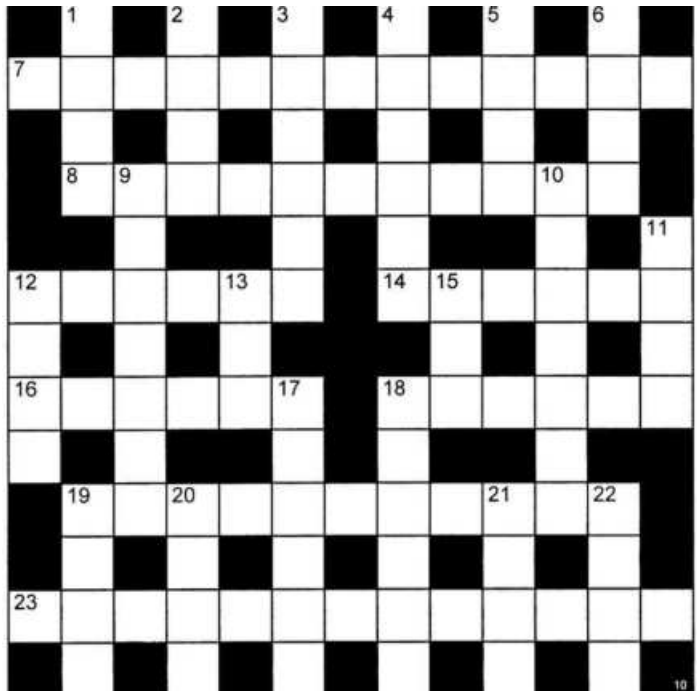
technologies will bring greater transparency with less expensive governance. There will be an increase in governance challenges related to cybersecurity, algorithmic risk, and systemic risk which will challenge the governance of Interconnectivity.

The future of financial governance will be defined by integration of finance, technology, risk, and sustainability into a coherent framework, which will involve investing in analytics, embedding real-time governance systems, and institutionalising risk culture.

Financial governance is no longer a defensive function; it is a source of competitive advantage.

The writer is MD & CEO, NCDEX. Views are personal

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2696



EASY

ACROSS

- 07. Female royal attendant (4-2-7)
- 08. Force into hasty action (11)
- 12. Cooking instructions (6)
- 14. Nullify; deny (6)
- 16. Stands in contention with (6)
- 18. Earlier than (6)
- 19. Cadging on others for meals etc (4-7)
- 23. Coin-operated gaming devices (5-8)

DOWN

- 01. Fresh-water fish (4)
- 02. Cow-house (4)
- 03. Not sagacious (6)
- 04. A country (6)
- 05. Volcano; liquid-heating device (4)
- 06. At one time (4)
- 09. Get back (7)
- 10. Dress worn in the afternoon (3-4)
- 11. Unit of DNA (4)
- 12. Very uncommon (4)
- 13. Chum (3)
- 15. Female sheep (3)
- 17. Continental sausage (6)
- 18. Whiten (6)
- 19. Class (4)
- 20. Wickedness (4)
- 21. Coloured part of eye (4)
- 22. Became larger (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2695

ACROSS 1. Discrepancy 7. Posture 9. Frog 11. Sleep 12. Absent 14. Ideological 18. Slaves 20. Award 22. Eats 23. Cleaner 24. Armour-plate

DOWN 2. Instead 3. Ewer 4. Curve 5. Spasm 6. Agate 8. Unproven 10. Abdicate 13. Box 15. Against 16. Aster 17. Adorn 19. Alter 21. Acer

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- 07. Lord's wife at home, hanging around for royal attendant (4-2-7)
- 08. Suddenly bring on a substance separated from solution (11)
- 12. What cook follows ravioli starter with piece of mince? (6)
- 14. Deny one lost head with those attending match (6)
- 16. They vie for parts in a play by Sheridan (6)
- 18. It preceded the beef, or troubles caused by it (6)
- 19. Eating at others' expense with no fee for putting it on board (4-7)
- 23. One-armed bandits got from Munich as reft is effected (5-8)

DOWN

- 01. Find small faults with the fish (4)
- 02. Where cows are housed around Derby without capital (4)
- 03. Foolish way to win, if in the habit (6)
- 04. The country is one that may be United (6)
- 05. Liquid heater occasionally eruptive in Sicily (4)
- 06. Sergeant perhaps turned east on a former occasion (4)
- 09. Get better half of the disc finished (7)
- 10. In which one may have been dressed at four (3-4)
- 11. Heredity transmitter usually skips the rally (4)
- 12. It's hard to find meat so underdone (4)
- 13. The chum Father left to drink up (3)
- 15. She bleats if we go after end of scene (3)
- 17. Sausage got in the mail as a change (6)
- 18. Left in place of the right tree limb to whiten (6)
- 19. Class that may need to be filled out (4)
- 20. Very bad, but very short, in fib that turns up (4)
- 21. Around Rhode Island is wrapped the flag (4)
- 22. Got bigger, as one was a gardener (4)

NEWS SNIPPETS.

Solex Energy in talks for solar venture in Ghana

Solar module manufacturer Solex Energy Ltd has proposed setting up an end-to-end solar manufacturing ecosystem in Ghana,



including local production of renewable energy components, technology transfer and workforce training, following discussions with a

delegation led by Ghana's High Commissioner to India Prof. Kwasi Obiri-Danso.

The proposal was discussed during the Ghanaian delegation's visit to Solex's headquarters in Surat. The two sides explored opportunities for cooperation in solar manufacturing, technology and renewable energy infrastructure as Ghana seeks to diversify its energy mix and expand clean energy generation.

Solex said the proposed partnership would be implemented in phases and would include skill development and technical training programmes to build a local renewable energy workforce. The company also expressed interest in collaborating with the International Solar Alliance (ISA) to support Ghana's clean energy transition.

The discussions come as several African countries are stepping up investments in renewable energy to improve energy security and reduce dependence on fossil fuels, creating opportunities for Indian solar manufacturers to expand overseas.

Solex currently has a photovoltaic module manufacturing capacity of 4 GW and plans to expand this to 10 GW by 2030. It also aims to establish 10 GW of solar cell manufacturing capacity under its Vision 2030 expansion plan.

Microalgae-based carbon capture system at oil refinery

Bhopal-based Mushroom World has deployed its microalgae-based carbon capture system at Indian Oil Corporation's refinery in



Vadodara, Gujarat, and Amanora Park Town, a residential township in Maharashtra, marking the

expansion of the technology to industrial and real estate applications.

The company said the deployments represent a step towards a wider commercial adoption of its AlgaeTree system, which uses microalgae housed in photobioreactors to capture carbon dioxide from ambient air or industrial flue gas. Through photosynthesis, the microalgae convert the captured carbon dioxide into oxygen and biomass, which can be processed into products such as biopellets and fertilisers.

Mushroom World described AlgaeTree as India's first commercialised carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS) solution. It said each photobioreactor is capable of capturing up to 1.5 tonnes of carbon annually, although the company did not provide independent validation of the claim.

The company said it has received inquiries from industrial units, real estate developers, educational institutions and public infrastructure projects in India, besides early commercial interest from overseas markets, including the UAE and Malaysia.

Mushroom World plans to expand AlgaeTree installations to more Indian cities and develop compact versions for offices, hospitals, hotels, educational institutions and airports.

It is also working on export-ready systems, renewable energy-powered variants and advanced monitoring technologies, as it seeks to scale up the deployment of the carbon capture solution.

RENEWABLE-RICH GRID

Why, at 42.79%, record RE penetration sparks not just cheer but also worry

TRANSITION PIT-STOP. Beyond installing more solar panels and wind turbines, an urgent need is to make the electricity system flexible

M Ramesh

At 12:29 hours on July 13, India achieved a record that went almost unnoticed. Wind and solar together accounted for 42.79 per cent of the electricity being generated in the country at that instant — the highest ever share of variable renewable energy (VRE) in the grid.

Wind and solar together were generating electricity at a rate of 103.7 GW, another record. (GW measures the rate at which energy is generated, much like the horsepower rating of a water pump indicates how much water it can move at any instant.)

Wind and solar had touched their individual milestones earlier. Wind's share in generation reached a record 17.13 per cent on July 12, while solar's highest penetration was 39.1 per cent on March 3.

The record renewable energy penetration on July 13, even if for a short duration, illustrates how far India has come in clean energy. Today, VRE capacity (wind plus solar), at 219.6 GW, accounts for 40 per cent of the total installed power capacity of 548.85 GW.

QUESTION OF GRID STABILITY

The high penetration of VRE is indeed a cause for celebration; equally, it is a warning to grid operators. VRE is good news for energy decarbonisation, but a headache for grid operators. If the output from wind and solar suddenly falls because the wind has dropped or clouds have rolled in, then another source — typically coal, hydro or storage — must step in almost immediately. Electricity generation



DOUBLE-EDGED. Variable renewable energy is good for decarbonisation, but a headache for grid operators ISTOCK

and demand must be balanced every second, otherwise the grid itself comes under stress.

The obvious answer is 'storage'. Batteries can absorb surplus solar electricity during the afternoon and feed it into the grid after sunset, when demand is high and solar generation stops. Recognising this need, India has begun awarding large battery energy storage projects. But storage alone cannot carry the burden. An oversized battery capacity built for storing the maximum generation is economically unwise.

That is why coal, ironically, has become an important enabler of renewable energy. India's coal stations were designed to run steadily as baseload generators. The Central

Electricity Authority (CEA) has laid down a roadmap for making coal plants more flexible, ultimately enabling many units to tune down, within minutes, their operations to as low as 40 per cent of their rated capacity. In practice, however, much of the fleet remains stuck at a minimum operating level of around 55 per cent. Running plants at lower loads reduces efficiency, increases wear and tear, and raises maintenance costs, which the generators are loath to bear.

FUNDING FLEXIBILITY

A renewable-rich grid, however, demands flexibility. The engineering solutions are largely known. The need of the hour are market instruments that help pay for flexibility.

Today's electricity market largely rewards generators for the number of units they produce. Tomorrow's grid will increasingly need mechanisms that reward flexibility and reliability.

Capacity markets — a concept newly introduced in India — compensate generators or storage providers for being available when the system needs them, even if only occasionally. They reward the ability to provide firm power whenever required. Such market instruments recognise that, in a renewable-rich grid, availability can be as valuable as generation itself.

Former GRID-INDIA chairman SR Narasimhan, commenting on the July 13 milestone, has argued that higher renewable penetration

must be accompanied by greater grid discipline.

GRID-INDIA has petitioned the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) for powers to disconnect renewable generators that repeatedly fail to comply with grid regulations. Renewable generators are mandated to equip their plants with low-voltage and high-voltage ride-through (LVRT and HVRT) capability — tools that strengthen grid resilience by enabling the generators to remain connected and support the grid during temporary voltage disturbances, instead of disconnecting and worsening the problem. The commission is yet to grant the permission — perhaps because there is a pushback from generators.

RENEWED STANDARDS

Narasimhan also urges the CEA to announce the "long-overdue" fresh (revamped) Technical Standards for Connectivity to the Grid Regulations.

The next phase of India's energy transition will be won not simply by installing more solar panels and wind turbines but also making the entire electricity system more flexible.

Crossing 100 GW of instantaneous wind and solar generation and 42.79 per cent of VRE penetration is a milestone that serves as a reminder for more work to reach the next milestone. The challenge is no longer in merely building green capacity but also ensuring that every unit of clean electricity can be absorbed, transmitted, and used. High renewable penetration is a much better problem to have than low renewable penetration. But it is a problem nevertheless.

HEATING UP

How solar thermal can 'green' manufacturing processes

K Bharat Kumar

The greening of the power grid through renewable energy is rightly in focus to help meet the country's commitment to achieving 'net-zero emissions' by 2070. However, another potential solution — solar thermal — remains overlooked.

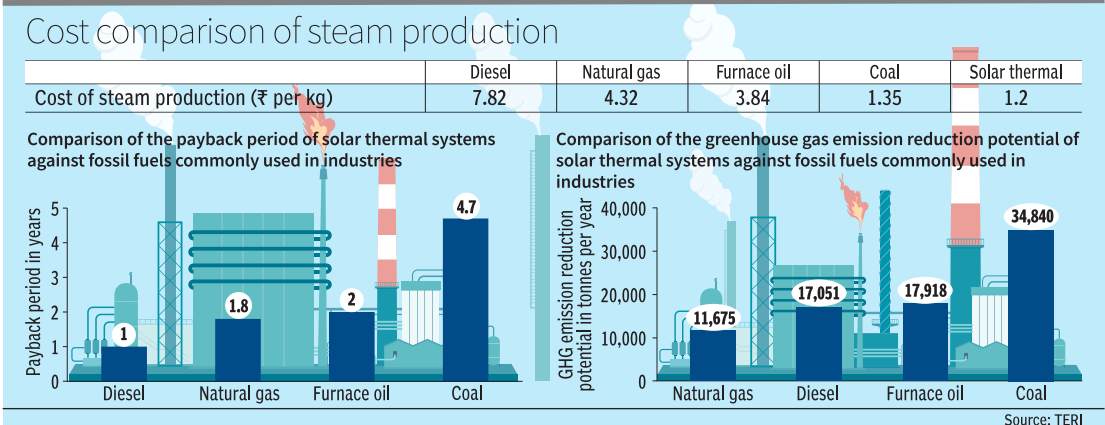
A major, silent challenge in industry is the need for 'process heat' — factories burn huge quantities of fossil fuels to boil water, create steam or run assembly lines. Solar thermal energy can be made available instantly, unlike the futuristic hydrogen fuel option.

A solar thermal system is designed to absorb heat energy directly from the sun's rays.

In a policy-brief note, The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI) says India needs a "National Solar Thermal Mission, on the lines of the National Solar Mission and the more recent National Hydrogen Mission", under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy.

APPLICATIONS

The real opportunity for solar thermal energy is in medium-temperature applications such as



steam, hot air, hot water generation and cooling.

It is, however, not suited for the kind of heavy-duty heating required in steel plants.

In pharmaceutical and food processing industries, thermal energy makes up 60–75 per cent of the energy mix used for distillation, sterilisation, and blanching.

Likewise, the dairy and textile sectors need huge amounts of hot water and steam for pasteurisation and fabric dyeing, respectively. Solar thermal lends itself well in such sectors.

It lowers not only carbon emissions but also costs, compared with

heat from fossil fuel. The note points out that these 'sunrise' sectors are expected to grow rapidly, as also their emissions, and would benefit from the use of solar thermal systems.

While solar thermal has been around for a while, it has not made a significant impact yet. TERI describes it as a chicken-and-egg situation — market failure on both the supply and demand side.

There are several reasons for the poor off-take: low awareness of the benefits; too little demand leading to poor supply; and the need to design solar thermal systems suited to specific needs, unlike solar pan-

els, which are mass-produced and have standard usage.

COST ADVANTAGE

Solar thermal is especially feasible owing to the abundant resource — the country enjoys 250–300 sunny days a year, with annual radiation of 1,600–2,200 kWh/sqm. The technology ranges from inexpensive, low-temperature collectors to advanced tracking systems that hit 400 degrees C.

It is highly competitive vis-a-vis electrification or hydrogen. When it comes to diesel, natural gas or furnace oil, while it costs ₹7.82, ₹4.32 and ₹3.84, respectively, to

produce 1 kg of steam, solar thermal costs only ₹1.2. But pitched against coal at ₹1.35, solar thermal may struggle to compete without policy support. Here's why: The payback period after switching from diesel to solar thermal is the quickest at one year, but from coal to solar thermal it could take as much as five years, making businesses hesitant to switch.

TERI points out that replacing coal-fired industrial boilers with solar thermal systems provides by far the greatest reduction in carbon dioxide emissions (35,000 tonnes per annum) for a 10 tonnes per hour boiler. This is twice the saving achieved by replacing diesel (17,000 TPA), and even more for natural gas or furnace oil (11,000–18,000 TPA).

With policy support, companies can surmount a combination of obstacles, including high upfront cost, land constraints, lack of tailored bank-financing, and shortage of skilled technicians.

TERI recommends that the government should allow 10-year, green bond-backed loans, drop GST to the lowest tier, offer 50 per cent accelerated depreciation, and set up industrial special purpose vehicles (SPVs) to share the infrastructure costs among clusters of factories.

The missing element in India's rare-earths scheme

What will it take for the country to cut import dependency and build a resilient critical-minerals ecosystem?

Anuj Gupta
Abhinav Jindal

India's ambitions in the areas of clean energy, electric mobility and advanced manufacturing rest on an uncomfortable reality: the minerals needed to power these sectors are sourced through global supply chains that are increasingly beyond the country's control.

Of the 33 minerals in demand, 24 face a high risk of supply disruption. India is entirely dependent on imports for 10 minerals, including cobalt, nickel and lithium.

China dominates the midstream — controlling over 90 per cent of rare-earth processing, 95 per cent of graphite processing and 79 per cent of refined cobalt production. Strategic leverage lies not at the mines but in beneficiation — separation, refining and oxide production.

In November 2025, the Union Cabinet approved a ₹7,280-crore scheme to build manufacturing capacity for 6,000

tonnes per annum of integrated rare earth permanent magnets (REPM), covering the value chain from rare-earth oxides to finished magnets for electric vehicles, wind turbines, and aerospace and defence applications.

However, the scheme faces several challenges. India produces some light rare-earth oxides through the public sector company IREL, including neodymium-praseodymium, but is dependent on imports for the heavy rare-earth oxides dysprosium and terbium.

Between 2022 and 2025, imports accounted for 60–80 per cent by value and 85–90 per cent by volume of the permanent magnets supplied in the country.

Without secure oxide supplies, India risks replacing one import dependency with another.

Three parallel strategies are needed to secure oxide supplies: diversified international off-take agreements for critical minerals from non-concentrated sources; ore-to-oxide processing capabilities built through technology partnerships; and development of do-



ISTOCK

mestic resources, including those in India's maritime domain.

OFFSHORE INFLECTION

India's 'exclusive economic zone' — the area of the sea extending up to 200 nautical miles (about 370 km) from the country's coastal baseline — spans about 2.37 million sq km. Seven auctioned offshore blocks near Great Nicobar contain polymetallic nodules

rich in cobalt, nickel, copper, manganese and rare earths. Beyond them, India's exploration contract in the Central Indian Ocean Basin covers an even larger resource. The National Critical Minerals Mission (NCMM), launched in January 2025 with an outlay of ₹34,300 crore, prioritises offshore mining.

Capability, however, lags ambition. India offered 13 offshore blocks for auction in November 2024, including

seven polymetallic nodule blocks valued at over ₹1.5 lakh crore. After several deadline extensions, the auction was cancelled in December 2025 after attracting no bidders. The reason was clear: Indian companies lack the specialised equipment and technology needed for deep-sea mining. Rather than ending India's offshore ambitions, the setback should reshape them.

PARTNERSHIP ARCHITECTURE

Japan offers a useful model. The Japan Organisation for Metals and Energy Security (JOGMEC) facilitates technology transfer in exchange for supply commitments — Japan and Lynas Rare Earths operate a three-country supply chain whereby ore mined in Australia is processed overseas before reaching Japan. This secures reliable midstream access without requiring every stage of the processing to be domestic.

India's future offshore auctions should similarly pair exploration rights with technology partnerships and long-term off-take agreements. Linking offshore development with India's oxide

requirements for the REPM programme could make deep-sea projects commercially viable while securing critical feedstock.

India's individual initiatives — the NCMM, the REPM scheme, offshore mining reforms and Khanij Bidesh India Ltd's overseas acquisition mandate — are all sound. The missing element is integration.

The oxide supply gap, processing technology deficit and offshore resource challenge are not separate problems but parts of the same value chain. A credible strategy must address all three together through diversified international supply, domestic processing capability built with global partners, and an offshore framework that attracts technology leaders rather than deters them.

India cannot build a resilient critical-minerals ecosystem one link at a time.

Anuj Gupta is MD of BowerGroupAsia and Abhinav Jindal is a senior faculty member at Power Management Institute and an energy economist. Views are personal

OFFICE BUZZ.

Portfolio careers

Gen Z professionals are rethinking their careers, driven by flexibility, AI fluency and multiple income pathways, rather than a single linear job, says new research from International Workplace Group (IWG), a provider of flexible



workspaces. The IWG research finds that rather than relying on a single employer or role, Gen Z is increasingly building “portfolio careers”, combining multiple income streams to future-proof work in an uncertain economic and technological landscape. It says 33 per cent of Gen Z workers already have, or are considering a side hustle to increase their financial security. This shift is closely tied to the growing influence of AI, with 55 per cent believing it will reshape their careers. In response, young professionals are proactively developing new skills and diversifying their income sources to stay adaptable as roles continue to evolve. The study reports that 65 per cent say they would be less likely to pursue entrepreneurship or multiple income streams if required to commute long distances daily.

Millennials in the C-suite

Millennials now represent 55 per cent of India's C-suite, making them the largest generational cohort among senior executives, finds the latest platform data from professional network LinkedIn. Millennial representation in India's C-suite has



grown 14.5 per cent over the last seven years. More interesting is the finding that single industry experience among India's C-suite leaders has dropped from around 80 per cent to 58 per cent, pointing to a leadership market where exposure across companies, functions and business contexts matters more. The LinkedIn research also finds that AI is adding urgency to this shift, with 84 per cent of Indian C-suite leaders saying it is creating new roles in their organisation. Leaders are also using AI more directly in decision-making, with 84 per cent saying inputs from AI tools are now a key step.

RENEWABLE RUSH

Inox Clean jumpstarts green growth

GROWTH PLAYBOOK. The company has spent over ₹25,000 crore in the past year on buyouts to build a global clean energy platform

Avinash Nair

For most renewable energy companies, growth follows a familiar script — projects are bid for, capacities are added and capital raised. But Inox Clean is trying to rewrite that playbook.

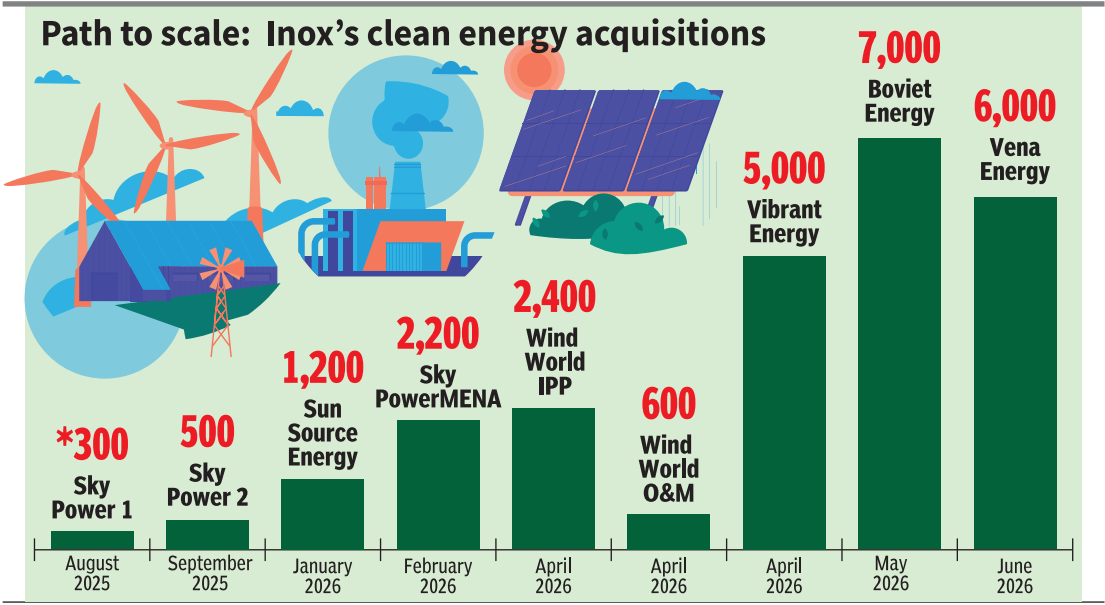
Over the past year, the INOXGFL Group-backed clean energy platform has spent more than ₹25,200 crore on a string of acquisitions stretching from India to West Asia and South-east Asia. The deals span renewable power generation, solar manufacturing, project development, operations and maintenance, and international assets. At first glance, the buying spree appears unusually intense — even by the standards of India's rapidly consolidating renewable energy sector. But the company insists that the objective is not simply to become bigger.

Says Devansh Jain, Executive Director, INOXGFL Group, “From the beginning we have been focused on building an integrated clean energy platform that spans manufacturing, project development, power generation and lifecycle services. The strategy is attracting investor attention. Adar Poonawalla Family Office's recent investment of ₹700 crore sent Inox Clean's valuation soaring to nearly ₹70,000 crore — the highest among India's privately held clean energy companies.

THE AMBITION

According to Jain, the company wants to grow its integrated clean energy platform into a “world leader” — a company measured not only by megawatts installed but also its ability to manufacture, develop, own and operate renewable energy assets across global markets. The ambition marks a significant evolution for the diversified INOXGFL Group. Best known for building businesses across the chemicals, fluoropolymers, wind energy and industrial gases segments, the group is now attempting to replicate its integrated model in clean energy.

For Inox Clean, the destination



extends well beyond becoming another large renewable energy developer. Rather than assembling a portfolio of unrelated companies, “every acquisition fits into a larger strategic architecture”, Jain says.

It started off with the acquisition of SkyPower 1 in August 2025, followed by SkyPower 2 a month later, giving Inox Clean an immediate portfolio of operating renewable energy assets. January 2026 saw the acquisition of SunSource Energy, strengthening the company's commercial and industrial (C&I) renewable energy business. A month later came SkyPower MENA, opening the door to overseas markets. April proved to be the busiest month — Inox Clean acquired Wind World IPP, while listed group company Inox Green purchased Wind World O&M, adding both operating renewable assets and long-term asset management capabilities. Around the same time, the acquisition of Vibrant Energy expanded its generation portfolio.

The strategy then moved further upstream. May saw the acquisition of Vietnam-headquartered Boviet Energy, providing an entry into integrated solar module manufacturing and strengthening backward integration. June brought in Singapore-based Vena Energy and a



INTEGRATING STRATEGY. Devansh Jain, Executive Director, INOXGFL Group

geographically diversified renewable portfolio across Asia. The proposed acquisition of Regen Energy awaits National Company Law Tribunal approval.

Taken together, Jain says, the transactions represent different pieces of the same puzzle — addition of renewable generation assets, expanded manufacturing, new markets, strengthened technology capabilities, and roping in experienced management teams.

FUNDING THE EXPANSION

The acquisitions and their funding inevitably raise questions over

leverage and capital allocation. According to Jain, every investment — whether organic or inorganic — is evaluated against the benchmark of long-term value creation. “In some cases, building organically makes sense. In others, acquisitions provide immediate scale, accelerate market access, strengthen capabilities or significantly reduce execution timelines. We do not see these as competing strategies,” he says.

The funding entailed a combination of internal accruals, equity capital and debt “while maintaining a disciplined approach to leverage”. The recent Adar Poonawalla Family Office investment and the preceding institutional backing have strengthened the balance sheet. Despite the dilution of stake, the promoter group continues to hold more than 90 per cent. Jain sees benefits beyond just capital infusion. “Having credible long-term investors strengthens governance, brings valuable perspectives and reinforces our commitment to disciplined execution,” he says.

He rejects the suggestion that the company is pursuing acquisitions simply because valuations have become attractive. “We are extremely disciplined in our evaluation process,” he says, pointing out that every acquisition satisfies

four filters — strategic alignment with the group's long-term vision; differentiated capabilities; sustainable shareholder returns; and cultural compatibility. “Integration is ultimately about people, and we invest significant effort in understanding whether organisations share similar values and execution philosophies,” he says.

THE INTEGRATED MODEL

Some of the transactions emerged through long-standing industry relationships, while others involved competitive bidding against domestic and international investors. The real work, however, begins after an acquisition.

Integrating businesses spread across multiple geographies, technologies and management cultures often proves significantly harder than the transactions themselves. “Execution begins after the acquisition closes,” Jain says.

Rather than imposing a uniform operating model, Inox Clean is integrating governance, financial controls, technology platforms and strategic decision-making while allowing the acquired businesses to retain operational autonomy, given that the management teams possess deep customer relationships and domain expertise.

“The biggest lesson has been that successful integration is built on trust, clarity of purpose and speed of execution,” Jain says.

Although India will remain the company's largest market, overseas acquisitions such as SkyPower MENA and Vena Energy underline a broader ambition. “Clean energy is inherently a global industry,” Jain says. “Our overseas investments are not driven simply by geographic diversification. They provide access to new technologies, broader customer markets and stronger supply chain resilience.”

As renewable energy projects become larger and supply chains are increasingly integrated, Jain expects industry consolidation to continue. “Companies with strong balance sheets, operational expertise and long-term strategic vision will be well positioned to lead this consolidation,” he sums up.

COMPUTE BOOM

Inside L&T Vyoma's AI factory in Chennai

Sindhu Hariharan
Rohan Das

Even as the AI boom is impacting businesses the world over, it is creating a serendipitous opportunity for India. As the soaring demand for GPU infra, coupled with power shortage in the West, forces companies to look towards India for data centre (DC) capacity, developers are racing to build AI-ready DCs.

L&T Vyoma, the digital infrastructure arm of Larsen & Toubro, is betting big on this window of opportunity and accelerating the expansion of its Chennai campus, which has transformed from a conventional DC into an “AI factory” serving varied customer needs.

After expanding from basic co-location services to private, public, and sovereign cloud options, L&T Vyoma's “AI factory” now deploys GPU clusters through a landmark Nvidia partnership.

A DIGITAL FORTRESS

A walk-through of the DC, located near Sriperumbudur on the outskirts of Chennai, offers a glimpse into a future that is already fast hurtling into the present. Entering the campus — after stringent security checks of the airport kind, complete with scanners, frisking and minute inspection of bags and purses — one feels one is stepping into a rarefied zone.

The eerie quietness intensifies this feeling. Unlike other mega factories that throb with the hum and hustle of people and machinery, the surreally quiet DCs are populated with racks of servers processing huge amounts of data. There are rows of servers in the hallways, alongside power electronics, cooling systems and back-ups for seamless operations. Several areas were off-limits to us, owing to client confidentiality requirements.

Once filled with CPU racks, the Chennai DC now hosts the coveted Nvidia H100s, H200s, and Blackwell GPUs, in step with technological shifts.

The nerve centre of a DC is its control room, where we encountered a small team monitoring



POWERING AI. The electrical room at L&T Vyoma's data centre in Chennai

everything from the temperature of individual racks to grid connectivity, and the parameters of the UPS and standby diesel generators.

There is also a dedicated security control room, where the CCTVs are equipped with AI-powered software to provide real-time alerts. It's a well-guarded fortress.

“Chennai is our flagship data centre campus, where we currently have a 30 megawatt IT load DC. We have power ready, network ready, permit ready for the second building, which we are kicking off, as we see significant demand for AI data centres,” says Prashant C Jain, Managing Director, L&T Vyoma, and Head of Electronic Products and Systems.

EXPANSION PIPELINE

L&T Vyoma has a second DC campus in Panvel, in Maharashtra's Raigad district. Alongside Phase 2 of the Chennai and Panvel campuses, the company's expansion pipeline includes the upcoming campuses at Mahape (in Navi Mumbai) and Bengaluru. The live capacity is around 30 MW (Chennai), 2 MW (Panvel); an additional 200 MW is set to go live in the short- to medium-term.

With the L&T group allocating ₹10,000 crore to the DC business, L&T Vyoma plans to invest about ₹9,000 crore across its campuses in FY27 itself, given the high demand for AI-ready infrastructure.

Jain does not rule out external funding in the future, adding that the nature of the funding would depend on the model of the DCs.



Prashant C Jain, Managing Director, L&T Vyoma, and Head of Electronic Products and Systems

Clients include neo-cloud players, banking and financial institutions, and commodity exchanges.

There is significant interest from hyperscalers, he says. The business is also constantly innovating and entering into partnerships to support new-age requirements. For instance, L&T Vyoma recently partnered with Fortanix Inc to offer sovereign, secure AI solutions using Nvidia confidential computing technology.

This model specifically targets regulated sectors in India, ensuring data sovereignty and compliance while enabling secure AI adoption. The two companies will jointly develop solutions, co-sell to industries, and engage with AI model builders to strengthen the ecosystem.

ENGINEERING EDGE

Jain says that while it typically takes 15-18 months to get a DC up and running, L&T with its engin-

earing, procurement and construction (EPC) strengths is constantly innovating to make this more efficient.

“L&T Vyoma has a significant advantage. We as a group have a strong EPC experience and competence, which we rely on. We also have good experience in realty and project management,” Jain notes.

What also sets Vyoma's Chennai DC apart is the fact that facilities designed for conventional cloud computing were re-engineered to handle dense GPU clusters, advanced cooling systems and massive power loads — a feat perhaps only an infra giant like L&T can accomplish.

L&T Vyoma is also exploring improvements in DC design to avoid dependence on power utilities when scaling up AI-ready DCs.

“We are evaluating technologies like battery energy storage system and grid forming inverters to support the grid. Such solutions will be a good hedge to support the grid, rather than expecting the grid to take more load,” says Jain.

This will also help the company increase its share of renewable energy usage, which is about 40 per cent today. “There is a clear roadmap to expand renewable blend; we are evaluating battery energy storage systems or PPAs (power purchase agreements) that include storage,” he says.

He sees accelerated demand not only from domestic sources but also global clients, as the West Asia crisis makes pockets of the world unsafe for business continuity.

Among the challenges faced, Jain says, one needs to stay constantly updated, given AI's pace of change. “I might start building assuming a certain base load and cooling requirements but, by the time the DC is up months later, the technology has likely made two shifts,” he points out.

Given the growing competition, what is the differentiator that L&T Vyoma brings to the DC race? “For [building] large AI-ready capacities going forward, there will be a need for strong balance sheets and strong execution capability, and who better than L&T with this advantage,” he stresses.

DEAL STREET

Punchy valuations fuel consumer M&A boom

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

Organic growth is no longer enough to conquer the modern consumer market. Across the board — from L'Oreal to Hindustan Unilever and Tata Consumer Products — FMCG giants have been snapping up brands to secure market share. Global financial services group Rothschild & Co has been advising companies on a range of transactions, including Coca-Cola's move to divest 40 per cent stake in HCCB to Jubilant Bhartia Group. It has also been retained to advise the beverage major on the potential public listing of HCCB in India.

In an interaction with *businessline*, Subhakanta Bal, Managing Director and Head of Healthcare and Consumer (India) at Rothschild & Co, spoke on the rising M&A activity in the consumer sector.

Edited excerpts:

How is the current M&A landscape in the consumer sector? Is there an uptick in the deals Rothschild & Co is advising on in India?

I would say M&A activity in the consumer sector has seen an uptick over time. This is one of the few sectors where we see significant interest from both private equity funds and strategic investors. Historically the challenge has been the lack of assets available for M&A. That seems to have changed. We have seen a wide pool of buyers showing interest in the inorganic route, including international players.

We have also seen a willingness to pay attractive valuations for assets. If one looks at some of the deals over the last 2-3 years, we have seen pretty punchy outcomes in valuations. We have also seen a pretty reasonable amount of private equity activity in this sector. Within consumer, there has been strong M&A activity



CONSOLIDATING ASSETS. Subhakanta Bal, MD and Head of Healthcare and Consumer (India), Rothschild & Co

in segments including food and beverage, and beauty and personal care. We have also seen a fair bit of activity in the B2B consumer segments that are essentially suppliers to branded players

M&A activity in the consumer sector will be less about buyer interest and financing and more about availability of assets. For us, globally, the consumer sector is the biggest amongst the core sectors. In India, in the last five to six years, there has certainly been a pickup in the volume of transactions we are advising on in the consumer sector.

Will this result in a wave of consolidations?

There's a clear recognition that growing brands organically in India is just extremely time-consuming and, therefore, in certain categories it just makes a lot of sense to do M&A, both from an industrial and a financial standpoint.

The rate of consolidation or M&A will really be a function of asset availability.

Are there enough potential assets for M&A in the consumer sector?

I would say it's better than five years ago. But if you're asking whether the pipeline of assets is as vibrant as in some of the

other sectors, I would say not yet, and there's a reason for that. Fundamentally, consumer is an asset-light sector; it's a cash-generating business that does not need too much capex. Working-capital cycles are typically very low, which means that if I am the owner of a mid-size consumer asset, frankly it's not like I'm putting more capital to work every year. If the business keeps growing, the trigger for an owner to sell is less compared to some of the other sectors.

What about the trend of international companies getting onto the IPO bandwagon in India?

We are seeing scaled-up businesses in the consumer sector wanting to tap capital markets. The consumer sector valuations, too, have been pretty attractive. The trend of MNC companies wanting to list their Indian subsidiaries has been a recent one, and is likely to continue. One of the things that have changed in India over the last 5-8 years is that the median size of companies going public has meaningfully gone up.

These days, large institutional investors want companies with a larger scale to go public, and they're not as keen on smaller assets.

The beauty and personal care sector is booming in India. What has led to a sharper focus on deals in this segment?

One is that conventional companies in this space now want to have a more meaningful foray into digital-first space, so a lot of D2C assets in beauty become pretty attractive targets. Also, there are many reasonably scaled-up assets on the digitally-native side, which was probably not the case even four years ago.

Some of these brands have demonstrated pretty strong growth in the last 3-4 years, making them more attractive as assets for larger players.

DATA BANK.

Sole proprietors drive the demand for small business loans

India's small business ecosystem, which includes commercial enterprises and individual business owners with an aggregate credit exposure of up to ₹5 crore from the formal lending system, has remained resilient amidst external headwinds with support from a favourable macroeconomic and policy environment, according to a CRIF High Mark–SIDBI report.

Total portfolio outstanding rose 13.4 per cent year-on-year (YoY) to ₹49.2 lakh crore in March 2026 (from 43.3 lakh crore), with 7.5 crore (6.7 crore) active loans, reflecting sustained credit penetration despite moderation from 17.3 per cent YoY in March 2025.

“The small business credit portfolio continues to expand steadily with double-digit growth, though the pace is showing signs of moderation (as of March 2026). Asset quality remains on an improving trajectory,” the report said.

Sole proprietors, namely individual business borrowers, continue to drive the growth of small business loans, accounting for 80 per cent of the portfolio and over 87 per cent of the active loans (inclusive of those with entity presence).

‘Loan against property’ (LAP) continues to be the dominant product in the consolidated portfolio (27.1 per cent of portfolio outstanding share, or POS) followed by business loans (24.8 per cent) and working capital products (22.8 per cent).

LAP share grew from 25.5 per cent in March 2025 to 27.1 per cent in March 2026, highlighting the continuing importance of secured credit in the MSME sector.

At the national level, the top 10 states account for 72 per cent of POS, underscoring market concentration. Growth, as of March 2026, is led by Andhra Pradesh (16.5 per cent YoY; 5.6 per cent quarter-on-quarter, or QoQ) and Uttar Pradesh (18.5 per cent YoY; 4.5 per cent QoQ). Cities beyond the top 100 outperformed the others with 21.6 per cent compound annual growth rate (CAGR) between March 2023 and March 2026.

Asset quality in the PAR (portfolio at risk) 90+ days segment improved from 4.2 per cent in March 2025 to 4 per cent in March 2026, with improvements across both PAR 91–180 and PAR 180+ buckets.

Enterprise term loans
The enterprise term-loan book stood at ₹6.7 lakh crore in March 2026, accounting for 25.9 per cent of the overall term loan POS across both sole proprietors and enterprises.

Growth in enterprise term loan POS slowed to 4.7 per cent YoY in March 2026 from 14.5 per cent, highlighting the opportunity available for lenders to finance technology upgradation, sustainability initiatives and capacity expansions in the MSME sector, apart from their working capital requirements.

Active loans in enterprise term loans declined 2.7 per cent YoY in March 2026, indicating slower account addition but with a shift towards higher lending.

In the lender mix, private banks led the enterprise term loan portfolio share at 31.2 per cent, followed by non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) at 27.9 per cent and public sector banks (PSBs) at 25.1 per cent.

In active loans, NBFCs were the largest players with 33.8 per cent share, followed by PSBs at 26.3 per cent and private banks at 24.1 per cent.

PSBs were the only major lender category that showed an acceleration in enterprise term loan POS growth in March 2026 (6.8 per cent YoY), while other lender groups slowed.

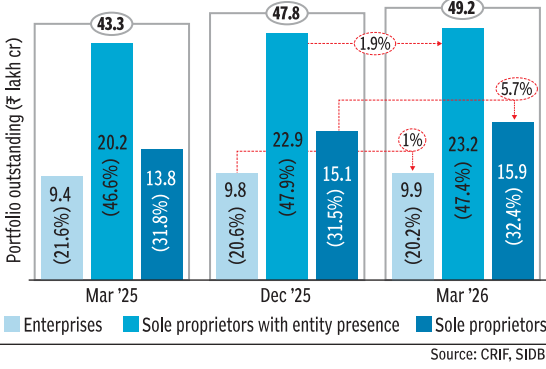
Delinquency in enterprise term loans remained broadly controlled, with PAR 31-90 and PAR 91-180 stable at 3.6 per cent and 1.6 per cent, respectively, as of March 2026.

Manufacturing accounted for 31.3 per cent of enterprise term loan share, while services and trading together comprised 47.6 per cent, reflecting a diversified sector mix. The remaining share was reported under ‘others’.

Overall small business credit exposure trends				
	Mar '24	Mar '25	Dec '25	Mar '26
Portfolio outstanding (₹ lakh cr)	36.9	43.3	47.8	49.2
YoY%		17.3	14.9	13.4
Number of active loans (cr)	6.3	6.7	7.5	7.5
YoY%		6.9	13.8	11.7
PAR 31-90%	3.1	3.3	3.5	3.1
PAR 91-180%	1.3	1.2	1.3	1.1
PAR 180+%	3.3	3.0	3.0	2.9

Portfolio outstanding is for credit exposure up to 720 days. PAR 180+ represents loans that are 181-720 days past due and reported to the bureau. However, this may include loan accounts that are likely written off by the lender and not reported separately under write-offs to the bureau.

Small business share and growth — by portfolio outstanding



● GOD’S OWN LENDER

Dhanlaxmi Bank eyes revenue milestone to mark centenary year

DEPOSITING FAITH. Temple-linked lender aims for ₹50,000 crore business by 2027 after three-digit net profit last year

V Sajeew Kumar
Chitra Narayanan

Thirissur-based Dhanlaxmi Bank, often referred to as “God’s Own Bank”, thanks to its long association with managing the accounts of the Sabarimala and Guruvayur Sree Krishna temples, is preparing to celebrate its centenary in 2027 on the back of a remarkable turnaround. The yearlong celebrations will kick off this November 14, said Chairman and Managing Director Ajithkumar KK.

After navigating a challenging phase between 2010 and 2022, the bank has staged a strong recovery over the past three to four years. The CMD attributed the transformation to the wholehearted support and cooperation of all stakeholders, including employees, customers and the board of directors.

“Today, we are growing at a double-digit rate and are targeting a consistent annual growth of 18–20 per cent. Given our smaller size, this is a realistic and sustainable aspiration,” Ajithkumar said, during an interaction at the bank’s swank new corporate tower in Thirissur.

The bank is aiming for ₹50,000 crore business by the conclusion of its centenary celebrations, from over ₹35,000 crore at present.

“We have reported our first-ever three-digit annual net profit of ₹100 crore in the last financial year, marking a significant milestone in our nearly century-long history,” he added, describing how the capital infusion of ₹300 crore through a rights issue has been judiciously used for growth and how the bank is strengthening its digital products.

Edited excerpts:

As you celebrate the centenary, what are the top three priorities for the next 12 months?

In credit growth, more thrust will be given to the retail (excluding gold) and MSME (micro, small and medium enter-



REFURBISHED LEGACY. Dhanlaxmi Bank’s old office (left) and its new corporate tower, in Thirissur



prises) segments to diversify the advances portfolio and improve the yield on advances. To have exponential growth in this segment, the bank proposes to centralise the processing of retail credit proposals by routing through the (digital platform) Loan Origination System (LOS). Corporate advances are projected with minimal growth and we prefer a cautious and selective approach in this segment.

The ongoing Core Banking Solution upgrade introduces a highly modular, scalable, and secured API architecture. This modernisation serves as the foundation for all future digital initiatives.

The LOS will be enhanced to support all product lines by adding MSME and corporate accounts. This upgrade fully digitises the end-to-end lending lifecycle, spanning lead generation, underwriting, documentation, and disbursement. Business correspondents will leverage AePS (Aadhaar-enabled payment system) capabilities to open accounts and process financial transactions in remote areas, thereby ensuring financial inclusion.

In branch expansion strategy, we are planning to open 25 new branches, mostly in south India. We will try to focus more on opening branches in Tamil Nadu, Telangana,

Andhra and Karnataka. Our presence in these states is moderate and we plan to open more branches there to capitalise on the bank’s identity. The bank has 265 branches currently.

Customer service will be another area of focus. Feedback and experiences received from customers will be handled professionally and a more customer-friendly product and process will be implemented. We have engaged a dedicated agency to provide a detailed study on this matter.

Given the RBI’s recent notification on raising dollar deposits, how are you planning to tap FCNR(B) lines or other foreign currency funding?

The RBI launched a special dispensation programme on June 5, offering a zero-cost dollar forex swap facility. To optimise the benefit, we have launched a new product, FCNR Maxigain. We offer a very competitive interest rate of 7.25 per cent. The swap facility is available up to September 30. It is expected to mobilise around ₹250 crore in this special product.

To significantly boost our NRI deposit portfolio, we have established a dedicated NRI cell at the head office. This strategic focus yielded impressive results last year, resulting in



Ajithkumar KK, Chairman and Managing Director, Dhanlaxmi Bank

the opening of a good number of new NRI savings accounts. The RBI’s swap facility has been highly encouraging, serving as a powerful tool for sourcing new NRI customers.

What are your current capital adequacy position and buffer levels, and any plans for equity or debt capital raising over the next six to 12 months?

The bank’s CRAR (capital to risk-weighted assets ratio) position is at 18.92 per cent (Basel III), as on March 31, which is well above the regulatory minimum of 11.5 per cent. The bank has a total capital of ₹1,573.23 crore, of which tier-I capital is ₹1,339.77 crore and tier-II capital is ₹233.46 crore. The tier-I capital ratio is at

16.11 per cent. At present, the bank is adequately capitalised.

What explains the robust bottomline growth, margin stability, and asset quality improvements in the previous quarter?

Our net interest income increased substantially due to an increase in interest income on loans (yield in advance increased to 10.17 per cent) by keeping our deposit funding costs at 5.61 per cent.

The robust lending across our business segments directly impacted our top-line revenue. The percentage of bad loans reduced significantly. The bank has maintained a high PCR (provision coverage ratio) and reduced gross NPA (non-performing assets) to 1.89 and net NPA to 0.51.

The cost-income ratio dropped to 55.66 per cent, compared to 79.78 per cent in Q3 and 84.03 per cent in Q2, due to an increase in total income during the final quarter and effective operational cost controls.

How have your current account (CASA) levels trended recently? What are you doing to lift low-cost deposits?

For FY2025-26 our CASA growth was 15.8 per cent. For Q12026-27 our YoY growth rate was 19.56 per cent, and during this fiscal we are targeting a 17 per cent growth.

We are giving more thrust on opening temple, school, and college accounts. We have tie-ups with various service providers to offer a comprehensive temple management platform and school fee management solution.

To enhance high-value savings account propositions such as NRIs, large trusts, and corporate PF and pension accounts, we offer 6.5 per cent for the balance above ₹5 crore kept in their savings account.

Recently we introduced the Aadhar-enabled Payment System. The corporate business correspondent operations will be leveraged for the sourcing and onboarding of liability products, thereby supporting CASA growth.

Underutilised loans against insurance policy

Policyholders can access funds against the surrender value, while keeping the life cover intact for long-term goals



RAJESH KRISHNAN

Life insurance products are designed to meet the long-term financial needs of individuals.

However, some financial needs arise unexpectedly — medical emergencies, education expenses, or temporary cash-flow gaps, among others — making timely access to liquidity essential.

Many individuals end up surrendering their life insurance policies to meet such unforeseen expenses, but premature surrender can erode the policy’s accumulated value and weaken long-term financial protection.

A loan against insurance policy (LAIP), available for select categories of life insurance products, bridges this gap by providing access to short-term liquidity while allowing the policy to continue and enabling the policyholder to benefit from its long-term advantages.

NEW-AGE EXPECTATIONS
Today’s customers expect seamless, digital-first experiences marked by speed, transparency, and simplicity.

The evolution of LAIP offerings increasingly reflects these preferences through paperless loan applications, digital submission of documents, faster eligibility checks, faster disbursements, and a transparent online tracking system.

By integrating technology with financial flexibility, many leading life insurers position LAIP as an intuitive and access-



NEX-GEN PRODUCT. Meeting children’s educational expenses need not entail losing the financial protection of a life insurance policy

ible liquidity solution. Access to this corpus can be significantly quicker, as the policy details are already available with the insurer, reducing the need for extensive documentation.

LAIP allows policyholders to access funds against the policy’s surrender value, while keeping the life cover intact. As a secured borrowing, it is generally a cost-efficient option compared with unsecured credit facilities.

LAIP VS PERSONAL LOAN

Policyholders often compare an LAIP with conventional personal loans when evaluating their liquidity options. While both provide access to funds, their structure and customer experience differ significantly. Some of the key differences are:

- LAIP does not require a credit appraisal of the individual and typically does not involve checking one’s credit bureau score, as the policy itself secures the loan.
- The interest rate is generally competitive when compared to personal loans. Moreover, personal loans may involve processing fees and other charges, which typically do not apply for an LAIP.
- Since the loan is accessed against an existing insurance policy, there is no need for a separate collateral. The policy itself serves as collateral.
- Most of the leading life insurers have digitised the LAIP process, enabling policyholders to access the loan efficiently through a largely digital journey with minimal documentation.

• Repayment options are generally flexible. Loan eligibility is reinstated as repayments are made and may increase further as renewal premiums continue to build the policy’s cash value.

However, an LAIP should not be viewed as a conventional bank loan. Rather, it functions more as a feature or benefit attached to an insurance policy. It may provide greater repayment flexibility without the usual EMI burden or concerns around hidden repayment hassles and charges.

Since the loan is against policy value, there is generally no financial assessment involved.

FINANCIAL GOALS

Life insurance supports long-term goals such as retirement planning, children’s education, wealth creation, and family income protection. Discontinuing a policy midway can dilute these objectives.

Financial strain is not merely numerical, it is also deeply emotional. Concerns about family responsibilities, fear of compromising future security, and anxiety about accessing credit can weigh heavily on individuals.

Knowing that liquidity can be accessed through an existing life insurance policy provides reassurance. It creates a sense of preparedness — the confidence that one can navigate financial challenges calmly without making reactive decisions.

WHO CAN BENEFIT?

Traditional life insurance policies with an established surrender value are generally eligible for an LAIP. These are typically conventional, savings-oriented or endowment-type policies rather than pure pro-

tection products.

Many policyholders have traditional savings-oriented plans that begin generating surrender value from the second or third policy year, depending on the product design, forming the basis for LAIP eligibility.

Policyholders can typically access 80–90 per cent of the surrender value as loan. Loan eligibility increases as surrender value grows and renewal premiums continue to be paid.

Depending on the policy tenure and premiums paid, the loan can range from moderate to substantial amounts, making it suitable for short- to medium-term liquidity needs.

Traditional insurance policies continue to form the primary base of the LAIP market in India. However, estimating the exact market size remains difficult as it depends on the type of products and the portfolios of individual insurers.

The segment appears to be witnessing a gradual traction and rising awareness among customers.

REDEFINING INSURANCE

As financial lifestyles evolve, insurance must evolve with them. Financial protection can no longer be viewed solely as a distant promise — it must also support present realities.

LAIP represents a shift in thinking: from static financial protection to dynamic financial empowerment.

Ultimately, financial confidence comes from knowing that the financial protection offered by a life insurance plan is not only for the future, but also when it is needed most.

The writer is Chief Operations and Customer Experience Officer, Bajaj Life Insurance

IT services sector hints at hiring stabilisation

India's IT services industry hints at hiring stabilisation in a macro-economically challenged Q1, after nearly a year-long churn in total headcount.

A photograph showing a large computer lab with many students sitting at long tables, working on their laptops. The room has large windows in the background.

route,” said Dharan from the team. Pras Ganesh, Executive Programme Director of Toyota Mobility Foundation, said the winners had successfully transformed the challenges of a historic city into opportunities for innovation.

big data and AI company and Nippon Koei, and Janjatra, a three-colour coded wayfinding solution by architecture and design firm The Urbanizer were declared winners of the \$3 million Sustainable Cities Challenge (SCC) Varanasi.

Behtarway by VOGIC AI and Nayichaal by Prameya Consulting were recognised as 'honourable mentions' for their contributions towards more inclusive and efficient mobility in Varanasi. These four were selected from a group of 92 innovators, who gave digital or 'phygital' solutions to solve Varanasi's chronic crowd management problem.

Right now, it is at eight locations but will be expanded to 50 locations, eventually 100 locations. Using data from the sensors, the innovators built an analytics engine and a simulation engine, which simulates the entire city's flow intensity.

As for the colour coding solution Janjatra from The Urbanizer, their solution involves diverting a percentage of people headed to the *ghats* or the Kashi Vishwanath Temple through bylanes in order to decongest the main road. Pilot projects involved yellow colour coding for temple, blue for *ghat* and red for exit.

“Their solutions have progressed beyond pilot concepts and now help city authorities manage overcrowding, while providing residents and visitors with a smoother, safer, and more convenient mobility experience in Varanasi,” he said.

The solution providers will be funded for a year by TMF. Would the government support them further? Urban Development Minister of Uttar Pradesh, A K Sharma indicated that there could be mechanism for that as "Kashi has willingness to change but without destroying its identity".

The reporter was in Varanasi at the invitation of TMF

bl.interview

challenge inviting cities from around the world that had mobility-related problems with a vision to solve them. Accordingly, we found 200 cities, from there we brought it down to 10 and then finally shortlisted it to three. These are Detroit in US, Venice in Europe and Varanasi in Asia. We wanted to bring the best innovations from around the world, and to do that we did a challenge in order to find the best solutions, and then try to integrate it into the city.

“We wanted to bring the best innovations from around the world and find the best solutions, and then try to integrate it into the city”

A portrait of Dr. N. Balakrishnan, a middle-aged man with grey hair and a beard, wearing a dark shirt. He is smiling slightly and looking towards the camera. The background is a blurred green outdoor setting.

We are trying to show that it doesn't have to only be based on public funding. It can also

Beta testing has been done and that is why we have selected the two winners and the two honourable mentions today. We have seen the potential of the solutions. Now we are trying to provide adequate funding at least for one year for them to be able to test it and trial it. Some of them are doing little longer than a year, but that is the runway that we try to provide for them to be able to then see what works, what doesn't work and then they can take it forward.

Beyond the funding period how will it work? What will be role of city administration?

be a business model. It can be a solution that can be sponsored by other people, or it can be a business model that works within the ecosystem of Varanasi. That's also part of our solution be-

sustainable solutions, most important thing is not just the idea, it's how to keep the solution going afterwards. Our whole point is to be able to bring the ideas, see how they work together, allow them to test it, give them

some momentum and funding to start. Then from there, we strongly support and we will continue to guide them for the next year.

rhymes well with the strong 12,000 headcount addition reported by Accenture this quarter," said Nuvama Institutional Equities following TCS results.

IT HEADCOUNT

Further, Tech Mahindra also talked about restarting campus hiring, even as its IT headcount of 74,689 employees in the quarter was down by 688 employees sequentially.

“Campus hiring has been volatile because we have had limited visibility into revenues. Now that our visibility is stronger, the campus hiring

PRECISION HIRING

"What is returning is precision hiring, not volume hiring. Entry-level openings fell 44 per cent in a year to 10,000, while captive-centre demand rose 31 per cent, the only cohort that grew. The contest is for people who

build, secure and govern AI systems inside enterprises, and for the specialists who validate what machines produce. Generation is becoming abundant; verification remains scarce," said Sanchit Vir Gogia, Chief Analyst and Founder at Greyhound Research.

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